

Punjabi, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Punjabi one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Gurmukhi letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read ਨਮਸਤੇ *and* learn what it means in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Gurmukhi simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Punjabi is an **Indo-Aryan** language — descended, like Hindi and Sanskrit, from an old common ancestor — and it is written in **Gurmukhi**, “from the mouth of the Guru,” the script the Sikh Gurus shaped to carry their scriptures. Two threads run through the book: Punjabi’s Sanskrit inheritance (shared with Hindi), and the deep **Perso-Arabic** layer it absorbed on the old road between Persia and India — so “thank you” is both the Sanskritic ਧੰਨਵਾਦ and the Persian ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ. Roots are traced to Sanskrit, to Persian/Arabic, and, where they reach, to the wider family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Punjabi out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real

words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

The Punjabi greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Gurmukhi script and the two faiths and two vocabularies that meet in Punjabi. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs.

1.1 ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ (*sat srī akāl*) — the Sikh greeting

The letters in this word

(If you already read Gurmukhi, skim this.) Gurmukhi runs **left to right** under a top line, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” ਸ sa, ਤ ta, ਰ ra, ਕ ka, ਲ la. A **vowel sign** changes the vowel (ਾ ā, ਿ i, ੀ ī); a word-initial vowel rides a carrier letter — ਅ is the “a”-carrier. So ਅਕਾਲ = *a-kā-l, akāl*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The name **Gurmukhi** means “from the mouth of the *Guru*” (ਗੁਰੂ *gurū* + ਮੁਖ *mukh*, “mouth/face”); the script was standardised by Guru Angad, the second Sikh Guru, to write the scriptures. The greeting itself is a small creed: ਸਤਿ (*sat*, “truth,” from Sanskrit *satya* — the same “being/truth” root behind English *sooth* and *soothsayer*) + ਸ੍ਰੀ (*srī*, an honorific “revered,” from Sanskrit *śrī*, “glory”) + ਅਕਾਲ (*akāl*, “timeless” = *a-* “not” + *kāl* “time/death,” from Sanskrit *kāla*). *Akāl* is a name of God in Sikhism, the Timeless One — so the greeting declares “God is the eternal Truth.”

Why it's said this way

Sat srī akāl is the greeting of Sikhs — said with folded hands, and serving as both hello and goodbye. It is a statement of faith as much as a greeting, which is why it carries such weight. (A Sikh will often answer it by repeating it back.)

1.2 ਨਮਸਤੇ (*namaste*) — the shared greeting

The letters in this word

New: ਨ *na*, ਮ *ma*, and ਤੇ *te* (ਤ + the *e*-sign ੇ). With ਸ from before, read ਨਮਸਤੇ as *na · ma · s · te*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਨਮਸਤੇ (*namaste*) = Sanskrit *namas* (“a bow”) + *te* (“to you”) — “I bow to you,” the very same word as Hindi *namaste*. Punjab is home to many communities; *namaste* is the more general, pan-Indian greeting, used across faiths, where *sat srī akāl* is specifically Sikh.

1.3 ਧੰਨਵਾਦ (*dhannavād*) — “thank you,” the Sanskrit way

The letters in this word

New: ਧ *dha* (breathy *d*), ਵ *va*, ਦ *da*, and the nasal dot ੱ (*tippi*) on ਧੰ *dhami*. Read ਧੰਨਵਾਦ as *dhami · na · vā · d*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਧੰਨਵਾਦ (*dhannavād*) = Sanskrit *dhanya* (“worthy”) + *vāda* (“a saying”) — the same Sanskrit “thank you” behind Hindi *dhanyavād* and Marathi’s. It is the formal, Sanskritic thanks.

1.4 ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ (*shukrīā*) — “thank you,” the Persian way

The letters in this word

New: ਸ਼ *sha* — the letter ਸ਼ (*sa*) with a dot beneath, a *pair bindi* that marks Perso-Arabic sounds. With ੁ (the *u*-sign) and ੀ, read ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ as *shu · ka · rī · ā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ (*shukrīā*) is *not* Sanskrit — it came through Persian from **Arabic *shukr*** (“gratitude”), the *same* Semitic root behind Arabic *shukran*. Punjab sat for centuries on the road between Persia and India, so Punjabi (like Urdu and Hindi) carries **two vocabularies**: Sanskrit (*dhannavād*) and Perso-Arabic (*shukrīā*). The dot under ਸ਼ is the script’s own record of that borrowing.

1.5 ਹਾਂ / ਨਹੀਂ (*hāṇ* / *nahīṇ*) — “yes” and “no”

The letters in this word

New: ਹ *ha*, and the nasal sign ਂ (*bindi*). ਹਾਂ (*hāṇ*) and ਨਹੀਂ (*nahīṇ*) — both end in a nasalised vowel.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਹਾਂ (*hāṇ*, “yes”) and ਨਹੀਂ (*nahīṇ*, “no”). The “no” sits on the ancient negative *na-* — the same Proto-Indo-European **ne* behind English **no**, **not**, Latin *non*, and Hindi *nahīṇ*. Punjabi’s “no” and English’s “no” are distant cousins.

1.6 Recap

Punjabi		Meaning
ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ	<i>sat srī akāl</i>	hello / goodbye (Sikh)
ਨਮਸਤੇ	<i>namaste</i>	hello (general)
ਧੰਨਵਾਦ	<i>dhannavād</i>	thank you (Sanskritic)
ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ	<i>shukrīā</i>	thank you (Persian)
ਹਾਂ / ਨਹੀਂ	<i>hāṇ / nahīṇ</i>	yes / no

Two threads run through even these first words: the **Gurmukhi** script, “from the Guru’s mouth,” carrying a Sikh greeting that is a small creed; and Punjabi’s **two vocabularies** — Sanskrit (*dhannavād*) and Perso-Arabic (*shukrīā*), the script itself marking the Persian words with a dot. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *merā nāṇ...* (“my name...”) — and Punjabi’s *tūṇ / tusīṇ* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) 👁 eyes (6) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** all 9 lessons.

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ਮੀਰਾ ਹੈ। (*merā nām Mira hai* — “My name is Mira.”)
ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ? (*tuhāḍā nām kī hai* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and root, then assembled.

2.1 ਨਾਂ (*nām*) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

ਨ (*na*) + ਾ̃ (the *kannā*, long ā) + ਂ (the *bindi*, nasal) → ਨਾਂ (*nām*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਨਾਂ (*nām*) ← Sanskrit *nāman*, from Proto-Indo-European **h₃nómn*. — the *same* ancient root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**), and Greek *onoma*. Punjabi *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed. (Hindi keeps *nām*; Punjabi nasalises the ending.)

2.2 ਮੇਰਾ (*merā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

ਮ (*ma*) + ੇ (the *lāvāṃ*, *e*-sign) → ਮੇ (*me*); ਰ (*ra*) + ਾ (long *ā*) → ਰਾ (*rā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਮੇਰਾ (*merā*, “my”) is on the first-person root *ma-* — the same *ma-/me-* behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *meus*.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees with the noun. *merā* (m.), *merī* (f.), *mere* (pl.). *nāṃ* is masculine, so *merā nāṃ*.

2.3 ਹੈ (*hai*) — “is,” cousin of English *is*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਹੈ (*hai*, “is”) ← Sanskrit *asti* (“is”), from PIE **h₁es-* — the root of “to be” across the family: English **is**, German *ist*, Latin *est*, Spanish *es*.

Grammar Lens

The verb goes last. Punjabi is *subject-object-verb*: “my name Arun *is*.” The *hai* sits at the end, where English puts “is” in the middle.

2.4 ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ...ਹੈ (*merā nāṃ ...hai*) — “my name is...”

ਮੇਰਾ (*my*) + ਨਾਂ (*name*) + ਨਾਂ (*name*) + ਹੈ (*is*) = “my name is...” *Merā nāṃ Arun hai*. The verb-frame comes last, as always.

2.5 ਤੂੰ and ਤੁਸੀਂ (*tūṁ*, *tusīṁ*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਤੂੰ (*tūṁ*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE *tū — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*. ਤੁਸੀਂ (*tusīṁ*, respectful) is grammatically plural — courtesy-by-plural, like French *vous*.

Grammar Lens

Two levels: *tūṁ* (familiar) / *tusīṁ* (respectful, also plural). For a first meeting, always *tusīṁ*.

2.6 ਕੀ (*kī*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਕੀ (*kī*, “what”) ← the interrogative stem *ka-*, from PIE *k^wo- — the same root behind English **wh-** words and Latin *qu-*. Punjabi’s questions nearly all start with *k-*: *kī* (what), *kaun* (who), *kad* (when), *kithē* (where), *kivēṁ* (how).

2.7 ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ? (*tuhāḍā nāṁ kī hai*) — “what’s your name?”

ਤੁਹਾਡਾ (*tuhāḍā*, “your,” the respectful possessive) + ਨਾਂ (name) + ਕੀ (what) + ਹੈ (is) = “**your name what is?**” — verb last, the question-word dropped into the object slot. The familiar “your” is *terā* (from *tūṁ*).

2.8 ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ (*khushī hoī*) — “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The full phrase is ਤੁਹਾਨੂੰ ਮਿਲ ਕੇ ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ (*tuhānūṁ mil ke khushī hoī*) — “having met you, happiness happened.” The key word ਖੁਸ਼ੀ (*khushī*, “happiness”) is **not** Sanskrit — it is **Persian** (*khush*, “happy”), marked by *two* pair-bindis (ਖ਼, ਷਼). So introducing yourself draws on Punjabi’s **two vocabularies**: Sanskrit (*nāṁ*, *hai*) and Perso-Arabic (*khushī*).

2.9 The whole exchange

Punjabi	English
ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ਮੀਰਾ ਹੈ।	My name is Mira.
ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ?	What’s your name?
ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਰੁਣ ਹੈ।	My name is Arun.
ਤੁਹਾਨੂੰ ਮਿਲ ਕੇ ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nāṁ* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *merā* (root *ma-*, English *my*), *hai* (Sanskrit *asti*, English *is*), *kī* (root *ka-*, English *what*), and *khushī* (Persian — the second vocabulary). Next chapter: *tusīṁ kivēṁ ho?* (“how are you?”) — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) 👁 eyes (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has:

ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ? (*tusīm kivēṃ ho* — “How are you?”)
ਮੈਂ ਠੀਕ ਹਾਂ, ਧੰਨਵਾਦ। (*maiṃ ṭhīk hām, dhannavād* — “I’m fine, thank you.”)

3.1 ਕਿਵੇਂ (*kivēṃ*) — “how,” another of the k-questions

The letters in this word

ਕ (*ka*) + ਿ (the *sihārī*, *i*-sign, before) → ਕਿ; ਵ (*va*) + ੇ + ਂ → ਵੇਂ.
Read *kivēṃ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਕਿਵੇਂ (*kivēṃ*, “how”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the same root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Punjabi’s questions nearly all begin with *k-*: *kī*, *kaṇ*, *kad*, *kithē*, *kivēṃ*.

3.2 ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ? — “how are you?”

ਤੁਸੀਂ (*tusīm*, respectful “you”) + ਕਿਵੇਂ (“how”) + ਹੋ (*ho*, “are”) — “you how are?”, the verb last. The copula set: *maiṃ hām* (I am), *tūṃ haiṃ* (you are, fam.), *oh hai* (he is), *tusīm ho* (you are, resp.).

Grammar Lens

Match the “you” to the verb: *tusīm ...ho* (respectful), *tūṃ kivēm haiṃ?* (familiar).

3.3 ਮੈਂ (*maiṃ*) — “I”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਮੈਂ (*maiṃ*, “I”) is on the first-person root *ma-* — the same root as *merā* (“my”) and behind English **me**, **my**. It takes the copula ਹਾਂ (*hām*, “am”). Watch the homophone: this *hām* (“am”) is spelled like the *hām* (“yes”) of Chapter 1 — context tells them apart.

3.4 ਠੀਕ (*ṭhīk*) — “fine,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ਠ (*ṭha*, a retroflex *th*) + ੀ (long *ī*) + ਕ (*ka*) → ਠੀਕ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਠੀਕ (*ṭhīk*) means “correct, right, fine, OK” — a native Indian word (shared with Hindi/Urdu), no European cousin. Put it together: ਮੈਂ ਠੀਕ ਹਾਂ (*maiṃ ṭhīk hām*) — “I am fine,” verb last.

3.5 ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ (*koī gall nahīṃ*) — “it’s nothing”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ literally “[there is] **no matter**” — *koī* (“any”) + ਗੱਲ (*gall*, “matter, talk”) + ਨਹੀਂ (*nahīṃ*, “not”). It serves as “it’s nothing / you’re welcome.” *Gall* is a warm native Punjabi word; *nahīṃ* you met in Chapter 1 — the ancient negative *na-*, PIE **ne*, behind English **no**, **not**, **none**.

3.6 The whole exchange

Punjabi	English
ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ?	How are you?
ਮੈਂ ਠੀਕ ਹਾਂ, ਧੰਨਵਾਦ।	I'm fine, thank you.
ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ।	It's nothing / you're welcome.

Roots banked: *kivēm* (the *k*- questions), *maiṃ* (*ma*-, English *me*), *thīk* (native), *nahīm* (PIE *ne, English *no*). Next chapter: the farewells.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) 👁 eyes (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

Chapter 1 gave you the formal ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ (*sat srī akāl*), which doubles as a goodbye. Real days end more warmly:

ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ! (*phir milāṅge* — “We’ll meet again!”)

4.1 ਫਿਰ (*phir*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਫਿਰ (*phir*) means “again, then” — a native Indo-Aryan adverb (the same word as Hindi *phir*) with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar job: it turns a parting into a promise.

4.2 ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (*milāṅge*) — “(we) will meet”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (*milāṅge*, “we will meet”) is the future of ਮਿਲਣਾ (*milṇā*, “to meet”), from Sanskrit *mil-* (“to join”) — the root of *milāp* (“a meeting”). The ending *-āṅge* is the plural future.

Grammar Lens

The future is an ending. *mil-* + *-āṅge* → *milāṅge* — no helper like English “will.”

4.3 ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (*phir milāṅge*) — “we’ll meet again”

ਫਿਰ (again) + ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (we will meet) = “**we’ll meet again**” — the everyday, hopeful goodbye, where *sat srī akāl* is the formal one. It is the same “promise of return” the whole subcontinent prefers (Hindi *phir milenge*, Bengali *āshī*, Tamil *pōy varugirēṇ*).

4.4 ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ (*rabb rākhā*) — “God keep you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ means “[may] **God** [be your] **keeper**” — ਰੱਬ (*rabb*, “God”) + ਰਾਖਾ (*rākhā*, “protector,” from *rakḥṇā* ← Sanskrit *rakṣ-*, “to guard”). The word for God, *rabb*, is itself **Arabic** (*rabb*, “lord”) — so this most Punjabi of farewells fuses an Arabic name for God with a Sanskrit verb of keeping: the two vocabularies in one blessing.

4.5 The farewells

Punjabi		Register
ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ	<i>sat srī akāl</i>	formal (Sikh greeting-goodbye)
ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ	<i>phir milāṅge</i>	everyday, “we’ll meet again”
ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ	<i>rabb rākhā</i>	a blessing, “God keep you”

Roots banked: *milāṅge* (*mil-* “to join”), *rabb* (Arabic “God”) + *rākhā* (Sanskrit *rakṣ-* “to protect”). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *maiṁ pañjābī boldā hāṁ*.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 4 of 5 lessons.

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ ਹਾਂ। (*maiṁ panjābī boldā hāṁ* — “I speak Punjabi.”)

5.1 ਬੋਲਣਾ (*bolṇā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਬੋਲਣਾ (*bolṇā*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (the same word as Hindi *bolnā*). Its ending -ਣਾ (*-ṇā*) is the point: **every** Punjabi infinitive ends in *-ṇā/-nā* — *bol-ṇā* “to speak,” *mil-ṇā* “to meet,” *rakh-ṇā* “to keep.” Strip it and you have the **stem** (*bol-*).

Grammar Lens

Stem + ending. *bol-dā* (speaking, m.), *bol-dī* (f.), *bol* (speak!). Every tense builds on a stem like this.

5.2 ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ ਹਾਂ — “I speak Punjabi”

ਮੈਂ (I) + ਪੰਜਾਬੀ (*panjābī*, the object) + ਬੋਲਦਾ (speak, m.) + ਹਾਂ (am) — “I Punjabi speaking am,” verb-frame last.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The name ਪੰਜਾਬੀ (*pañjābī*) is **Persian**: ਪੰਜ (*pañj*, “five” — a distant cousin of English **five**, Latin *quinque*, Greek *pente*) + ਆਬ (*āb*, “water, river”) = “the [language] of the **five rivers**,” for the five great rivers of the Punjab. The very name is a Persian geography lesson.

Grammar Lens

The present habitual is gendered. A man: *maiṁ pañjābī boldā hāṁ*; a woman: *...boldī hāṁ*. The *-dā/-dī* marks the speaker’s gender.

5.3 ਰਹਿਣਾ (*rahiṇā*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਰਹਿਣਾ (*rahiṇā*, “to live, remain, stay”), from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain,” the same as Hindi *rahnā*): *maiṁ Amritsar rahindā hāṁ* (“I live in Amritsar”). Punjabi, like Hindi, uses **postpositions** (*vic*, “in”) — often dropped with a place-name — where English uses prepositions.

5.4 ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ (*kamm karnā*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਕਰਨਾ (*karnā*, “to do, make”) is from Sanskrit *kr-* (“to do”), PIE **k^wer-* — the root you met in Chapter 1’s *namaskār* (*namas* + *kār*, “the making of a bow”) and in *karma*. Punjabi builds compounds as **noun** + ਕਰਨਾ: ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ (*kamm karnā*, “work-do” = “to work”), *gall karnā* (“to have a chat”). So *maiṁ kamm kardā hāṁ* = “I work.”

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Punjabi	English
ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ/ਬੋਲਦੀ ਹਾਂ।	I speak Punjabi.
ਮੈਂ ਅੰਮ੍ਰਿਤਸਰ ਰਹਿੰਦਾ/ਰਹਿੰਦੀ ਹਾਂ।	I live in Amritsar.
ਮੈਂ ਕੰਮ ਕਰਦਾ/ਕਰਦੀ ਹਾਂ।	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, the $-dā/-dī$ that agrees in gender, and the copula that agrees in person — the verb always last. Roots banked: *bolḡā*, *rahḡā* (*rah-* “remain”), *karnā* (*kṛ* — root of *namaskār*, *karma*), and *panjābī* (*panj* “five” + *āb* “river”). From here, Punjabi’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to five in Gurmukhi, tell the addak apart from the tippi, and show that ਪੰਜ is inherited from Sanskrit rather than borrowed from the Persian panj in Punjab.

Set Punjabi ਪੰਜ beside Persian panj and argue the match is convergence, not borrowing: post-nasal voicing carried pañca to panj on the Indo-Aryan side, with panjāh against Hindi pacās as the evidence, while Iranian panč voiced separately.

6.1 ਇੱਕ, ਦੋ, ਤਿੰਨ, ਚਾਰ, ਪੰਜ — one to five

Four of these are new. The fifth you have known since **Chapter 5** — you just didn't know it was a number.

You'll want to know: the five

	Punjabi	said
1	ਇੱਕ	<i>ikk</i>
2	ਦੋ	<i>do</i>
3	ਤਿੰਨ	<i>tinn</i>
4	ਚਾਰ	<i>chār</i>
5	ਪੰਜ	<i>panj</i>

This is **Gurmukhi**, not Devanagari — a related but distinct script. It does have a top line like Devanagari's, so words hang from a bar in the same way.

Two marks worth telling apart, because they look similar and do different jobs:

- ੳ — the **addak**, on *ikk*. It **doubles the following consonant**.
- ੱ — the **tippi**, on *tinn* and *panj*. It marks a **nasal**.

(So *tinn*’s double *n* is not the addak’s doing — that word is spelled with a nasal mark, and the doubling is in the pronunciation.)

What you’ve built: ਪੰਜ as a number

Chapter 5 took the name ਪੰਜਾਬੀ (*panjābī*) apart for you: Persian ਪੰਜ *panj*, “five,” plus ਆਬ *āb*, “water” — the language **of the five rivers**. You learned *panj* there as a piece of a place-name. Here it arrives as what it actually is: **the number five**, an ordinary word you will count with.

The next prerequisite-ordered lesson explains an important twist: Punjabi’s numeral and the Persian word reached the same *panj* shape independently.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ikk, do, tinn, chār, panj”
- the two marks — “**addak** doubles, **tippi** nasalises”
- the Ch. 5 callback — “**panj** + **āb** = five rivers”

Before you move on

Count to five in Punjabi. (*Ikk, do, tinn, chār, panj*.) What script is this? (**Gurmukhi** — related to Devanagari, and it has a top line too.) What does ੳ and ੱ each do? (**Addak** doubles the following consonant; **tippi** marks a nasal.) Chapter 5 told you *panjābī* means “of the five rivers.” What has changed now? (***Panj* is a number you can count with, not just a piece of a name.**) Next: learn why Punjabi and Persian both say *panj*.

6.2 Why two branches both arrived at *panj*

Say “five” in Punjabi. (*Panj*.) Where did Chapter 5 first show that shape? (Inside Persian *panj* + *āb*, “five waters.”)

What you’ve built: the surprising family comparison

language	“five”
Sanskrit	<i>pañca</i>
Hindi	<i>pāñch</i>
Bengali	<i>pāch</i>
Gujarati	<i>pāch</i>
Punjabi	<i>panj</i>
Persian	<i>panj</i>

The neighbours keep a **-ch** shape. Punjabi matches Persian **-j**, but the obvious borrowing story is wrong.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Punjabi *panj* is inherited from Sanskrit *pañca*. North-western Indo-Aryan regularly **voiced a stop after a nasal**, turning *-ñc-* into *-nj-*.

Punjabi **panjāh** “fifty” (from Sanskrit *pañcāśat*) makes the rule visible; Hindi **pacās** shows the same source changing differently.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Persian independently voiced ancestral *č* to *j*: Iranian *panč* became *panj*. Two Indo-Iranian branches therefore reached the same shape separately:

branch	path
Punjabi	Sanskrit <i>pañca</i> → nasal-triggered <i>-nj-</i>
Persian	Iranian <i>panč</i> → voiced <i>panj</i>

This is **convergence, not borrowing**. The **place-name** *Punjab* is Persian; Punjabi’s look-alike **numeral** is inherited from Sanskrit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- Punjabi's path and proof — Sanskrit *pañca* → post-nasal *-nj-*; *pañāh* / *pacās*
- Persian's path and the conclusion — *panč* → *panj* independently; convergence, not borrowing
- Persian place-name, inherited Punjabi number

Before you move on

Borrowed from Persian? (No: Punjabi *panj* inherits Sanskrit *pañca*.) What made *-nj-*? (A post-nasal stop voiced.) Evidence? (*Pañāh* / *pacās*.) Persian's path? (Its ancestral *č* voiced separately.) In *Punjab*, what is Persian? (The place-name; Punjabi's number is homegrown.)

Chapter 7

Six Verbs at the Core

Modes: ੴ voice (6) ੴ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name six everyday Punjabi verbs by the -ੴ/-ੴ ending, strip that ending to reach the stem, trace each one to its Sanskrit and Indo-European root, and explain how the lost breathy consonants left Punjabi with a tone no other major Indo-Aryan language has.

The sixth verb runs the whole chapter at once: hold the doubled n that keeps jāṇnā apart from jāṇā, separate the two ੴ that came from different Sanskrit sounds, strip the stem off all six infinitives, and state that none of them carries a tone.

7.1 ੴ — “to be,” and the two old verbs braided inside it

You have been saying ੴ *hai*, “is,” since Chapter 2. Here is the verb it belongs to — and it sounds nothing like it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ੴ — *hoṇā* — to be

Four shapes, hanging from the top line: ੴ *h*, with the ੴ sign on it for *o*; then ੴ, an *n* made with the tongue tip curled back; then ੴ for long *ā*. It reads *ho-ṇā*.

The ending -ੴ -ṇā is how Punjabi names a verb — the same ending that sat on *bolṇā*. English names a verb by putting a word in front of it,

to *be*; Punjabi puts an ending on the back and never uses a separate word. Take that ending off and what remains is the **stem: ho-**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

hoṇā comes from Sanskrit *bhavati*, “becomes,” built on the root *bhū-*. Middle Indo-Aryan softened that *bh-* to *h-*, so *bhavati* thinned to *hoi* and then to **hoṇā**.

The root is Indo-European, **b^huH-*, “grow, become.” English keeps it in **be** and **been**, and — by way of “the place where one dwells” — in **build**, **booth**, and **bower**. Latin held it as *fuī* “I was” and *futūrus*, which English borrowed as **future**. Greek held it as *phúsis* “nature,” which English borrowed as **physics**.

Grammar Lens: one verb, two roots

Chapter 2 traced **hai** to a different Sanskrit verb altogether — *asti*, “is,” the root behind English **is**, Latin *est*, German *ist*. So Punjabi’s “to be” is **two ancient verbs braided into one**: the name and the stem come from *bhū-*, the everyday present tense comes from *as-*. English braids the very same two, at the very same seam, and nobody notices: *am*, *is*, *are* belong to the *as-* verb; *be*, *being*, *been* belong to the *b^huH-* verb.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **hoṇā** — to be
- *Strip*: **hoṇā** minus **-ṇā** leaves the stem **ho-**
- *Connect*: **hoṇā** ← *bhavati* → English **be**
- *Connect*: **hai** ← *asti* → English **is**

Before you move on

Which ending names a Punjabi verb, and what is left of *hoṇā* once you take it off? (**-ṇā**; the stem **ho-**.) And why do *hoṇā* and *hai* not resemble each other at all? (They are two different ancient verbs braided into one — the *bhū-* verb and the *as-* verb, exactly as English braids *be* with *is*.)

7.2 ਜਾਣਾ — “to go,” and a sound law you can run yourself

Name the ending that turns a Punjabi stem into the verb’s plain name. (-ਣਾ -*ṇā*.) Here is the second verb to wear it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਜਾਣਾ — *jāṇā* — **to go**

ਜ *j*, then ਾ *ā* long *ā*, then ਣ — the curled-back *ṇ* you already met inside *hoṇā* — then ਾ *ā* again. Nothing new to decode. Strip the -ਣਾ and the stem is *jā-*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

jāṇā is Sanskrit *yāti*, “goes,” on the root *yā-*, “travel.” The *y* became a *j*, and that was not an accident about this one word. Early Indo-Aryan turned **every** initial *y-* into *j-* on the way to Punjabi, and the change is regular enough to run backwards yourself:

- Sanskrit *yoga* → Punjabi **jog**
- Sanskrit *yuvan* “young” → Punjabi **javān**
- Sanskrit *yamunā*, the river → Punjabi **Jamnā**

So a Sanskrit word beginning *y-* is very often a Punjabi word you half know already, hiding behind a *j*.

The root itself is Indo-European, **yeh₂-*, “to go, travel” — the same verb as Lithuanian *jóti*, “to ride.” It is one of the rare cases where English inherited nothing usable, so the prize here is the rule, not the cousin.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **jāṇā** — to go
- *Strip:* **jāṇā** minus -*ṇā* leaves the stem **jā-**
- *Run the rule:* *yoga* → **jog**, *yuvan* → **javān**, *yamunā* → **Jamnā**
- *Connect:* **jāṇā** ← Sanskrit *yāti*, “goes”

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit verb is *jāṇā*, and what happened to its first sound? (*Yāti*, “goes”; the *y-* became *j-*.) Give one more word the same change caught. (*Jog*, *javān*, or *Jamnā*.)

7.3 ਆਉਣਾ — “to come,” which is “go” pointed back at you

You can say *jāṇā*, “to go.” Its opposite is not a different verb. It is the same verb with one small piece stuck on the front.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਆਉਣਾ — *āuṇā* — to come

ਆ is a whole syllable on its own, long *ā*: a Punjabi word cannot start with a bare vowel sign, so a vowel that opens a word rides a carrier letter. Then ਉ for *u*, then the familiar ਣਾ ending. It reads *ā-u-ṇā*, three beats. The stem is *ā-*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

āuṇā goes back to Sanskrit *ā-gacchati*, “comes.” Take that apart and it is the prefix *ā-*, “toward, hither,” sitting on the verb **gam-**, “go.” Punjabi’s “come” is literally *go-toward-me*, and the *g* wore away over the centuries until only the rounded *-u-* was left of it.

That prefix is a tool, not a one-off: Punjabi keeps *ā-* in the sense of motion **toward** the speaker, the same job English does with a separate word.

And **gam-** is the good part. It is Indo-European **g^wem-*, “to step, go” — and English inherited it straight down the Germanic line as **come**. Latin took the same root as *venīre*, which English then borrowed back many times over: **advent**, **invent**, **convene**, **venue**, **event**, **revenue**, **intervene**, **souvenir**. Greek took it as *baínein*, “to step,” giving English **base**, **basis**, and **acrobat**.

So when a Punjabi speaker says *ā*, the second syllable of that word is the same ancient step as your own *come*.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **jāṇā** to go, then **āṇā** to come
- *Split:* **ā-** toward, plus **gam-** go
- *Connect:* **gam-** ← **g^wem-* → English **come, advent, acrobat**

Before you move on

What two pieces are inside **āṇā**? (The prefix **ā-**, “toward,” and the old verb **gam-**, “go.”) Which everyday English verb is that second piece? (**Come.**)

7.4 ਖਾਣਾ — “to eat,” and the tone hiding one letter away

This verb is easy. Its neighbour in the alphabet is the strangest thing in the whole language, and this is where you meet it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਖਾਣਾ — *khāṇā* — to eat

ਖ is *kh*: a *k* with a puff of breath after it, as in English *back-hand* said fast. Then ਾ, then the ending ਾ. The stem is **khā-**.

It comes straight from Sanskrit *khādati*, “chews, eats.” No English cousin has been securely traced from that root, and that is fine — the prize in this word is its **sound**.

The letters in this word

Gurmukhi keeps its consonants in rows of five. The *k*-row runs ਕ *ka*, ਖ *kha*, ਗ *ga*, ਘ — and that fourth letter was once *gha*, a *g* said with a breathy voice.

Punjabi lost those breathy-voiced sounds. It did **not** lose the words. When ਘ *gh* starts a word it is now said as a plain *k*, and everything the old consonant carried moved onto the vowel as a **low, rising pitch**. Same elsewhere in the word, in mirror image: the pitch falls instead. That leaves pairs which are spelled differently and pronounced identically, apart from the tune:

Punjabi	said
ਘੋੜਾ horse	<i>kòṛā</i> , pitch dipping then rising
ਕੋੜਾ whip	<i>koṛā</i> , pitch level

Two words, one string of consonants and vowels, and the only difference is music. That makes Punjabi the one major Indo-Aryan language with **tone** — Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, Gujarati, and Marathi have nothing like it.

Your ਖਾਣਾ is safe: ਖ *kh* is voiceless, it never had the breathy voice, so it never traded anything for a tone. *Khāṇā* is said flat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **khāṇā** — to eat — flat, no tune
- the pair — *kòṛā* horse, dipping; then *koṛā* whip, level
- the rule — the old breathy *gh* went and left a pitch behind

Before you move on

What separates *kòṛā* “horse” from *koṛā* “whip”? (Pitch alone — the first dips and rises.) Where did that pitch come from? (From ਘ, an old breathy *gh* that stopped being breathy.) And does *khāṇā* carry one? (No — ਖ *kh* has no voice to lose.)

7.5 ਵੇਖਣਾ — “to see,” a verb built out of the eye itself

The ਖ *kh* you learned in *khāṇā* turns up again here, in the middle of a word this time. Same puff of breath, same flat pitch.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਵੇਖਣਾ — *vekhṇā* — to see, to look

ਵ *v*, with the ੇ sign on it for *e*; then ਖ *kh*; then the ending ਣ. It reads *vekh-ṇā*, and the stem is **vekh-**.

Punjabi also says ਦੇਖਣਾ *dekhṇā* for the same thing, which is the form Hindi settled on. One word, two front consonants, both alive in Punjabi — *vekhṇā* is the more homely, more Punjabi-sounding of the two.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

vekhṇā comes from Sanskrit *prekṣate*, “looks at” — the prefix *pra-*, “forth,” on the verb *īkṣ-*, “see.” And *īkṣ-* is built on *akṣi*, the Sanskrit word for the **eye**. Punjabi’s verb for seeing is, underneath, the organ you do it with.

That noun is Indo-European, **h₃ek^w-*, and English is full of it.

Inherited plainly: **eye** — and **window**, borrowed from Norse *vindauga*, a “wind-eye,” the hole that let the smoke out. Borrowed from Latin *oculus*: **ocular**, **binoculars**, **inoculate**. Borrowed from Greek *ōps* and *optikós*: **optic**, **optician**, **autopsy** (seeing for oneself), **synopsis**, **myopia**.

So *vekhṇā*, *eye*, *window*, and *autopsy* are four settlements of one very old word for the thing in your head.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **vekhṇā** — to see — then its twin **dekhṇā**
- *Strip*: **vekhṇā** minus **-ṇā** leaves **vekh-**
- *Connect*: *īkṣ-* ← **h₃ek^w-* → English **eye**, **optic**, **window**

Before you move on

What noun is hiding inside *vekhṇā*? (The **eye** — Sanskrit *akṣi*, behind the verb *īkṣ-*.) Name two English words off that root. (Any of **eye**, **window**, **ocular**, **optic**, **autopsy**.) And what is the Hindi-shaped twin of this verb? (*Dekhṇā*.)

7.6 ਜਾਣਨਾ — “to know,” one letter from “to go”

Run the five you have — *hoṇā*, *jāṇā*, *āuṇā*, *khāṇā*, *vekhṇā* — and pull the stem off each one. The sixth is the closest of them all to English.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਜਾਣਨਾ — *jāṇnā* — to know

ਜ *j*, ਾ long *ā*, then ਣ — the curled-back *ṇ* — and then a second, different *n*: ਨ, made with the tongue on the teeth. Then ਾ. Both are pronounced, one after the other: *jāṇ-nā*, held long across the seam, the way English does in *thin-ness*.

That second letter is the whole difference between ਜਾਣਾ *jāṇā* “to go” and ਜਾਣਨਾ *jāṇnā* “to know.” The stem here is **ਜਾਣ-**, and because it already ends in the curled-back *ṇ*, the infinitive shows up in its other shape, plain -ਨਾ -*nā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਜਾਣਨਾ continues Sanskrit *jānāti*, on the root *jñā-*, “know.” Note what that means for the rule from *jāṇā*: these two Punjabi verbs both open with ਜ *j*, but from different sources — *jāṇā*’s *j* was a Sanskrit *y*, while *jāṇnā*’s was already there, in *jñā-*.

That root is Indo-European **ǵneh₃-*, and English is stuffed with it. Down the Germanic line: **know**, **knowledge**, **can** (once “to know how”), **cunning**, **ken**, and **uncouth**, which is “un-known.” Borrowed from Latin (*g*)*nōscere*: **notice**, **note**, **notion**, **cognition**, **recognize**, **acquaint**, **narrate**, and **ignore** — “not to know.” Borrowed from Greek *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, **agnostic**.

Your turn

- *Contrast*: **ਜਾਣਾ** to go, then **ਜਾਣਨਾ** to know, holding the long *n*
- *Run all six*: *hoṇā*, *jāṇā*, *āuṇā*, *khāṇā*, *vekhṇā*, *jāṇnā*, stripping each stem
- *Say it*: the two sources — *jāṇā*’s *j* from *yā-*, *jāṇnā*’s from *jñā-*
- *Say it*: not one of the six carries a tone — every stem is flat
- *Connect*: *jñā-* → English **know**, **notice**, **diagnosis**

Before you move on

What single written mark separates *jāṇā* from *jāṇnā*? (A second *n*, the dental ਨ, held long in speech.) Where did each verb’s *j* come from? (*Jāṇā*’s from a Sanskrit *y*-; *jāṇnā*’s from *jñā-*.) And which

English verb is the very same word as *jāṇnā*? (**Know.**)

Chapter 8

The Mind, the Page, and the Falling Tone

Modes:  eyes (4)  Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Punjabi, hear and produce the falling tone that ਸਮਝਣਾ and ਪੜ੍ਹਨਾ carry where a breathy consonant used to be, read a subjoined ਓ tucked under its neighbour, and name what each of the four roots meant before it named an act of the mind — burning, waking, reciting aloud and scratching.

Say ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਪੜ੍ਹਦਾ ਹਾਂ and ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਲਿਖਦਾ ਹਾਂ in your own gender, then run the chapter's four verbs back to the physical acts their roots named — sochnā from a root meaning to burn and then to grieve, samajhnā from one meaning to wake, parhnā from one meaning to recite aloud, likhnā from one meaning to scratch — and pick out the two that are said with a falling pitch and the one that writes its ਓ underneath the letter.

8.1 ਸੋਚਣਾ — “to think,” and it once meant “to burn”

Āṇā handed English **come** outright, and *jāṇnā* — the one with the doubled *n*, one letter away from *jāṇā* “to go” — simply **is** English **know**. This verb hands over nothing, and its history is the oddest so far.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਸੋਚਣਾ — *sochṇā* — to think

Take off the familiar -ਣਾ and the stem is **soch-**. That stem stands alone as a noun too: ਸੋਚ *soch*, “a thought” — and, just as ordinarily, “a worry.” Hold on to that double meaning; the history is about to explain it.

The letters in this word

ਸ *s*, carrying the ੋ sign for *o* — the *horā*, a small hook above the letter. Then ਚ *ch*, a plain *ch* with no puff of breath. Then the ending ਣਾ. It reads *so-ch-ṇā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

sochṇā comes through Prakrit *soccai* from Sanskrit *śocyate*, and behind that stands the root **śuc-**, whose first meaning is “to burn, to glow.” Its second meaning is “to grieve.”

The sense cooled by stages: *burn* → *be eaten up by something* → *brood on it* → plain *think*. Punjabi's ordinary word for thinking is an old word for being on fire, which is exactly why **soch** is a thought and a worry at once.

The same root gives Sanskrit *śoka*, “sorrow” — and *a-śoka*, “without sorrow,” which is the name the emperor **Aśoka** carried. A word for grief sits inside both a Punjabi verb and one of the most famous names in Indian history.

State the limit plainly: *śuc-* has **no secure English cousin**. Other verbs gave you one; this one does not, and inventing one would be worse than saying so.

Your turn

- Say it: **sochṇā** — to think — then strip it to the stem **soch-**
- Say it: both senses of the noun **soch** — a thought, and a worry
- Say it: the chain — *burn* → *grieve* → *brood* → *think*
- Run through: *āunā*, *jānnā*, *sochṇā* — come, know, think

Before you move on

What did the root under *sochṇā* mean first? (**To burn**, then **to grieve**.) What famous name is built on it? (**Aśoka** — “sorrowless.”) Does it have an English cousin? (**No**.) And which of your earlier verbs *is* English **know**? (*Jāṇnā*, not *jāṇā*.)

8.2 ਸਮਝਣਾ — “to understand,” and the tone you can hear in it

Say *sochṇā* and name what its root meant first. (**To burn**, then **to grieve**.) Now the pair from *khāṇā*’s lesson — *kòṛā* the horse, *koṛā* the whip. That dip is about to turn up inside a word.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਸਮਝਣਾ — *samajhṇā* — **to understand**

Strip the *-ਣਾ* and the stem is **samajh-**. Like *soch*, it is also a noun: ਸਮਝ *samajh*, “**understanding, sense**.”

The letters in this word

ਸ *s*, ਮ *m*, then ਝ, then ਣ — *sa-majh-ṇā*. ਝ is new, and it is what this lesson is about.

The letters in this word

ਝ is the fourth letter of the *ch*-row, once *jha* — a *j* said with a breathy voice, the kind Punjabi gave up. In ਘੋੜਾ *kòṛā* it stood **first**, and the pitch it left was **low and rising**. Here it sits after the first vowel, and the rule mirrors: the breath goes, and the pitch on the vowel **before** it goes **high and falls**.

So ਸਮਝਣਾ is written with a *jh* and said without one. An acute marks that falling pitch, the twin of the grave on *kòṛā*:

written	said
ਸਮਝਣਾ <i>samajhṇā</i>	<i>samájṇā</i> , high then dropping
ਖਾਣਾ <i>khāṇā</i>	<i>khāṇā</i> , level — ਖ had no voice to lose

Punjabi has been shedding breathy sounds for a long time. Your first verb shows an older round: Sanskrit *bhū-* had a breathy *bh*, and ਹੋਣਾ *hoṇā* comes out with a plain ਓ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

samajhṇā continues Sanskrit *sambudhyate* — *sam-*, “together,” on **budh-**, “**to wake, to become aware.**” To understand is to wake up to something. That root named a person: *buddha* means “**awakened,**” the title the **Buddha** carries.

And *budh-*’s breathy *dh* is the very sound that became this word’s ਝ: *budhyate* went to Prakrit *bujjhai* and on into *samajh-*. The falling pitch is the last trace of that root’s old breath.

The root is Indo-European, **b^hewd^h-*, which English keeps in **bode** — as in “this bodes well” — and in **forebode** and **forbid**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **samajhṇā** as it is said — *samájṇā*, high then falling
- **khāṇā** straight after it, level, so the difference is audible
- the rule — first in the word the pitch rises; later, it falls
- *budh-* → **Buddha**, “the awakened”

Before you move on

Where does the pitch fall in *samajhṇā*, and why? (On the vowel **before** ਝ, where that letter’s old breath went; in *kòṛā* the letter stood first and the pitch **rose** instead.) What did *budh-* mean, and who is named from it? (**To wake**; the **Buddha**.)

8.3 ਪੜ੍ਹਨਾ — “to read,” which used to mean “to say out loud”

Say *samajhṇā* as it is actually said, pitch going high and dropping, and name the root behind it. (*Budh-*, “to wake.”) This

verb carries the same fall — and the letter that puts it there sits somewhere new.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਪੜ੍ਹਨਾ — *paṛhnā* — **to read**, and also **to study**

The stem is **paṛh-**, and its *h* is not breath. It is the falling pitch again: *páṛnā*, high on the vowel and dropping. Punjabi writes this verb both ਪੜ੍ਹਨਾ and ਪੜ੍ਹਣਾ; this book uses the first.

The letters in this word

ਪ *p*, then ਝ *r* — a flapped *r* made with the tongue tip curled back and struck forward. Then the new thing, then ਨਾ.

Every Gurmukhi letter so far has hung from the top line that runs across a word. ਝ breaks that habit: it is ਚ shrunk and tucked **underneath** its neighbour, so ਝ plus a subjoined ਚ is written ਝੜ. Gurmukhi has a small set of these subjoined forms, and this is the commonest.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

paṛhnā comes through Prakrit *paḍhañ* from Sanskrit **paṭhati**, and *paṭhati* has nothing to do with the eye. It means “**recites, reads aloud, rehearses, declaims.**” Reading was named as something the mouth does.

Set that against your verb for seeing: ਵੇਖਣਾ *vekhñā*, whose twin is *dekhñā*, is built on the **eye** itself. Only one of the two is an eye-word, and it is not the reading one.

No dead metaphor: the same root gives ਪਾਠ *pāṭh*, a **recitation of scripture** read aloud end to end — and Gurmukhi is the script the Sikh Gurus shaped to carry exactly that.

Where *paṭh-* itself came from is **not settled**, so this lesson claims no English cousin for it.

Your turn

- Say it: **paṛhnā** as it is said — *páṛnā*, high then falling
- Say it: where the ਚ sits in ਝੜ — underneath, not on the line
- Say it: what *paṭhati* meant — **to recite aloud**

- *Contrast:* *vekhṇā*, built on the **eye**; *paṛhnā*, built on the **voice**

Before you move on

What did *paṭhati* mean? (**To recite aloud.**) So which organ names Punjabi's reading verb, the eye or the mouth? (**The mouth.**) And what is unusual about the ਼ in ਙ੍ਹ? (It is **subjoined** — tucked below, not hung from the top line — and it is heard as a falling pitch, not as breath.)

8.4 ਲਿਖਣਾ — “to write,” which is scratching

Say *paṛhnā* with its falling pitch, and say what *paṭhati* meant. (**To recite aloud.**) You can read now. The fourth verb is the other half of that, and then the chapter closes with a sentence you can actually use.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਲਿਖਣਾ — *likhṇā* — **to write**

The stem is **likh-**. The ਖ here is a plain aspirated *kh*, a real puff of breath — no falling pitch anywhere in this word. Two verbs in a row carried a tone; this one does not.

The letters in this word

ਲ *l*, then ਖ *kh*, then ਣ. The short *i* has a quirk worth knowing: its sign ਿ is written **before** the letter it is pronounced after, so *li* comes out as ਲਿ — sign first, consonant second. It still hangs from the same top line as everything else.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

likhṇā is Sanskrit **likhati**, whose plain meaning is “**scratches, scrapes.**” Writing was named after what a sharp point does to a surface.

Two other languages reached that picture without help from this one. Latin *scribere* also meant “to scratch,” and English borrowed it wholesale as **scribe, script, describe, inscription.** And English's own **write** is Old English *writan*, “to scratch, to carve” — what you

did to a piece of wood with a knife to make a rune. Three languages, three separate decisions, one idea: writing is cutting a mark into something.
Beyond Indo-Aryan, *likh-*'s relatives are **disputed**, so this lesson names none.

Your turn

Chapter 5 gave you the frame ਮੈਂ ... -ਦਾ/-ਦੀ ਹਾਂ. Drop the new stems into it:

- [YOU SAY (m.): *māim paṇjābī paṛhdā hāmī* · (f.): *māim paṇjābī paṛhdī hāmī*]
- [YOU SAY (m.): *māim paṇjābī likhdā hāmī* · (f.): *māim paṇjābī likhdī hāmī*]
- *Say it:* which verb the ਹਾਂ in those sentences belongs to (*hoṇā*), and which of its two braided roots that present tense comes from (*as-*, not *bhū-*)

Before you move on

Say “I write Punjabi” in your own gender. Now run the chapter’s four verbs back to what their roots meant before they meant anything mental: *sochṇā* (**to burn**, then **to grieve**), *samajhṇā* (**to wake**), *paṛhnā* (**to recite aloud**), *likhṇā* (**to scratch**). Which two of the four are said with a falling pitch? (*Samajhṇā* and *paṛhnā*.) And which of them writes its *h* underneath the letter? (*Paṛhnā*.)

Chapter 9

Taking, Asking, Helping, and What Pleases You

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can take, ask, help and say what I like in Punjabi, build a fresh verb by putting a noun in front of ਕਰਨਾ, tell an inherited word from a borrowed one by its line of descent rather than by how it looks, and say why ਮੈਨੂੰ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਪਸੰਦ ਹੈ has no room for me as its subject.

Say ਮੈਨੂੰ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਪਸੰਦ ਹੈ and hear that you are not its subject, swap any infinitive into the middle slot, and run the chapter's four verbs back to where each came from — *laiṇā* worn down from Sanskrit *labhate*, *puchhṇā* from *prcchati* and cousin to Persian *porsīdan* without either being a loan, *madad* genuinely borrowed from Arabic through Persian, and *pasand* a Persian noun whose *pati-* 'toward' does the same job as the *ā-* of ਆਉਣਾ.

9.1 ਲੈਣਾ — “to take,” worn down to almost nothing

Last chapter's four verbs were all about the mind and the page. Say *likhṇā* and name what its root meant. (**To scratch.**) Say *parhṇā* with its falling pitch. These next four are about hands and other people.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਲੈਣਾ — *laiṇā* — to take

The shortest stem you have met: **lai-**, one syllable and no consonant after the vowel at all.

The letters in this word

ੴ *l*, carrying the ੐ sign for *ai* — two short strokes above the letter, the *dulaṅkaṛ*. It is the same sign that sits on ੐ *māim*, “I.” Then the ending ੐. Two shapes and a vowel mark: *lai-ṇā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

laiṇā comes through Prakrit *lahai* from Sanskrit **labhate**, “takes, obtains, gets.” Watch the middle of the word disappear: *la-bh-ate* → *la-h-ai* → *lai*. The breathy *bh* thinned to a plain *h*, the *h* fell away, and the two vowels left standing next to each other ran together into **ai**. That is a third road for an old consonant, and you have the other two. In ੐ *jāṇā* a Sanskrit *y*- **hardened** into *j*. In *samajhṇā* a breathy *dh* **turned into pitch**. Here a breathy *bh* simply **left**.

The root is Indo-European, **lebʰ-*, “to gain, to profit.” Greek took it as *lápura*, “spoils of war,” and Lithuanian as *lōbis*, “treasure.” English inherited nothing usable from it, so no cousin is claimed here — the prize in this word is watching it wear away.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **laiṇā** — to take — then the stem **lai-**
- the wearing-down, slowly — *labhate* · *lahai* · *lai*
- the three roads a consonant took — *jāṇā*’s *y* **hardened**, *samajhṇā*’s *dh* **became pitch**, *laiṇā*’s *bh* **left**

Before you move on

What happened to the *bh* of *labhate*? (It thinned to *h* and then **disappeared**, and the vowels ran together.) Name the other Punjabi verb whose first consonant changed identity, and say what it was before. (*Jāṇā* — its *j* was a Sanskrit *y*.) Does *laiṇā* have an English cousin? (**No**.)

9.2 पृच्छा — “to ask,” and a Persian cousin that is not a loan

Say *laiṇā* and say what wore away inside it. (A breathy *bh*, gone through *h* to nothing.) This next verb kept everything, and then doubled it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

पृच्छा — *puchhṇā* — to ask

The stem is **puchh-**, and the consonant in the middle is **held**: say *puchchṇā*, leaning on it, the way English leans on the middle of *bookkeeper*.

The letters in this word

प *p* with उ for *u* tucked under it; then ृ, the *addak* from Chapter 6 — the little mark that says “**double the next consonant**”; then छ *chh*, a *ch* with a puff of breath; then ण. The *addak* is doing all the work in this word: without it you would say *puchhṇā* light and quick, and with it the middle is long.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

puchhṇā comes through Prakrit *pucchai* from Sanskrit **pr̥cchati**, “asks.” The root behind it is Indo-European **prek-*, and it is one of the widest in the family.

Latin took it twice. *Precārī*, “to beg, to pray,” gave English **pray**, **prayer**, **precarious** (held only by asking) and **deprecate**. *Poscere*, “to demand,” gave English **postulate**. German still asks with it every day: *fragen*. Old English had *frignan* for “ask,” and English simply lost it.

Why it’s said this way

Persian asks with the same root: *porsīdan*, “to ask.” Set it beside *puchhṇā* and nothing matches — no shared consonant you could point at — yet they are relatives, because both come down from **prek-* along separate lines.

Chapter 6 made the opposite point with the same two languages. There, Punjabi *panj* and Persian *panj* matched **exactly**, and the

answer was still that neither borrowed from the other; each voiced its own ancestor's sound. So looking alike proved nothing there, and looking different proves nothing here. Only the line of descent settles it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **puchhṇā** with the middle held long, then the stem **puchh-**
- *Say it:* what the *addak* does (doubles the consonant after it)
- *Say it:* the English words off this root — **pray, precarious, postulate**
- *Run through:* *laiṇā, puchhṇā* — take, ask

Before you move on

Which mark makes the middle of *puchhṇā* long? (The **addak**.) Name two English words from the same root as *puchhṇā*. (Any of **pray, prayer, precarious, postulate**.) Is Persian *porsīdan* a loan into Punjabi or a cousin of *puchhṇā*? (**A cousin** — same root, separate lines.)

9.3 ਮਦਦ ਕਰਨਾ — “to help,” which is two words

Say *puchhṇā* with its long middle, and say whether Persian *porsīdan* borrowed from it. (**Neither** — cousins.) This verb *is* a borrowing, openly, and it is not even one word.

You'll want to know first — two words

ਮਦਦ ਕਰਨਾ — *madad karnā* — **to help**

ਮਦਦ *madad* is a noun, “**help**.” ਕਰਨਾ *karnā* is “**to do**,” the verb already inside Chapter 5's ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ *kamm karnā*, “to work.” Punjabi helps by **doing help**.

Note the ending: *karnā* takes plain -ਨਾ, not -ਣਾ, because its stem already closes on ਰ.

The letters in this word

ਮ *m*, ਦ *d*, ਦ *d* — the whole of *madad*, and **no dot beneath anything**. Chapter 1’s ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ *shukrīā* needed a dotted ਸ for a borrowed sound. This borrowing needed no new letter at all.

Grammar Lens: noun plus ਕਰਨਾ

This is a pattern, not a one-off. Put almost any noun in front of ਕਰਨਾ and you have a verb; ਕਰਨਾ carries the endings and the noun never changes.

- ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ *kamm karnā* — “work-do” — **to work**
- ਗੱਲ ਕਰਨਾ *gall karnā* — “talk-do” — **to have a chat**

That is Punjabi’s second way of building a verb from more than one piece. ਹੋਣਾ *hoṇā* is one word braided from **two ancient roots**, *as-* and *bhū-*, and its seam is invisible. Here the seam is the point: two whole words side by side, one of them borrowed.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਮਦਦ is **Arabic** — *madad*, on the three-consonant root **m-d-d**, “**to stretch out, to extend**.” Help is named as reaching something out.

It travelled through **Persian**, the road that carried *shukrīā*.

Chapter 6 asked whether a Punjabi word resembling a Persian one had been borrowed, and the answer was **no**: *pañj* is inherited from Sanskrit *pañca*, and *pañjāh* against Hindi *pacās* proved it. Ask that here and the answer is **yes** — there is no Sanskrit path to *madad* at all. Same test, opposite answers.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **madad karnā** — help-do — to help
- [YOU RUN the pattern: *kamm karnā*, *madad karnā*, *gall karnā*]
- *Say it*: which half is Arabic and which is Sanskrit (*madad* · *karnā*)
- *Run through*: *laiṇā*, *puchhṇā*, *madad karnā* — take, ask, help

Before you move on

What does *madad karnā* say literally? (“**Help-do.**”) What did the Arabic root mean? (**To stretch out, extend.**) Was *panj* borrowed from Persian, and is *madad*? (No, and yes.)

9.4 ਪਸੰਦ — Punjabi does not like things; things please Punjabi

Laiṇā, *puchhṇā*, *madad karnā* — say them, and say which is built on the noun-plus-*karnā* pattern. In all three you are the one acting. The fourth takes that away.

You’ll want to know first — ਮੈਨੂੰ, the shape of “to me”

ਮੈਨੂੰ — *mainū* — to me

This is what ਮੈਂ *maimi*, “I,” becomes when a sentence refuses to let you be its subject. It is not “I.”

The letters in this word

ਯ *p*, ਸ *s* carrying the ੰ *tippī*, then ਦ *d* — the same nasal mark that sits inside ਪੰਜ *panj*, and again on the ੂ of ਮੈਨੂੰ. As with *madad*, no new letter and no dot beneath.

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

ਮੈਨੂੰ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਪਸੰਦ ਹੈ। — *mainū pañjābī pasand hai.* — I like Punjabi.

Word for word: **to me** · **Punjabi** · **pleasing** · **is**. The thing liked is the subject, and ਹੈ agrees with it. No Punjabi sentence puts *I* in front of *like*. Any -ਣਾ infinitive drops into that middle slot, because a Punjabi infinitive doubles as a noun:

ਮੈਨੂੰ ਪੜ੍ਹਨਾ ਪਸੰਦ ਹੈ। — *mainū paṛhnā pasand hai.* — I like reading.

Unrelated languages keep Punjabi company: Spanish *me gusta*, Italian *mi piace*, Tamil *enakku piḍikkum*. Different families, borrowing nothing

from one another, each deciding that liking happens **to** you.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਪਸੰਦ is **Persian** and it is not a verb. It is ***pati-**, “**towards**,” on ***sand**, “**to look good**.” A word that cannot be conjugated cannot carry the liker, so the grammar moved that person out to ਮੈਨੂੰ.

You own a verb built the same way: ਆਉਣਾ *āunā*, “to come,” is **ā-**, “toward,” glued to a root meaning “go.”

Where ***sand** goes next is **proposed, not settled**: one line ties it to the root behind Latin *candēre*, “to glow” — English **candle, candid** — and Sanskrit *candra*, “moon.” Lovely, and not secure.

Chapter 6’s rule had no work to do here. It voiced a stop after a nasal and carried *pañca* to *pañj*; ਪਸੰਦ arrived from Persian with its **-nd-** already in place. Like *madad*, a loan rather than an inheritance.

Your turn

- Say it: *mainū pañjābī pasand hai*, then its word-for-word sense
- [YOU SWAP the middle: *paṛhnā · likhṇā · sochṇā*]
- Sort: *laiṇā*, *puchhṇā* **inherited**; *madad*, *pasand* **borrowed**

Before you move on

In *mainū pañjābī pasand hai*, what is the subject, what part of speech is *pasand*, and which prefix in it means “toward”? (ਪੰਜਾਬੀ; a **noun**, from Persian; ***pati-**, doing the job **ā-** does in ਆਉਣਾ.) Now the chapter’s four sources — *laiṇā* (Sanskrit *labhate*), *puchhṇā* (Sanskrit *pr̥cchati*), *madad* (**Arabic**, through Persian), *pasand* (**Persian**).

Chapter 10

Water, Tea, Milk, and Bread

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ◉ eyes (3) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can politely ask for water, tea, milk, or bread in Punjabi, name which of the four is a loanword and which is inherited with an unknown root, and hear the difference between a tone that stays level and one that never formed at all.

The chapter closes on ਰੋਟੀ, the request that breaks the drink pattern: the reader produces all four requests with ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ, sorts ਪਾਣੀ and ਦੁੱਧ (inherited, known root) against ਚਾਹ (loaned from Chinese by the overland route, carrying Punjabi's first noun-level tone) against ਰੋਟੀ (inherited, root unknown), and names the first Punjabi chapter to realize polite requesting at all.

10.1 ਪਾਣੀ — the first thing you'll actually ask for

Pasand let you say what pleases you; *madad karnā* let you ask for help. This chapter asks for something smaller and far more frequent: a drink.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਪਾਣੀ — *pāṇī* — water

The letters in this word

ਪ *p*, ਾ long *ā*, then ਼ — the curled-back *ṇ* you already read in ਜਾਣਨਾ — and ੀ long *ī*. Nothing here is new; every letter is doing work you have already made it do.

Grammar Lens: asking politely

ਪਾਣੀ, ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ। — *pāṇī, kirpā karke.* — **Water, please.**

ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ *kirpā karke* is built from ਕਿਰਪਾ, “kindness, grace,” plus ਕਰਕੇ, “having done” — the same ਕਰ- you already own from ਮਦਦ ਕਰਨਾ, “to do a favour of help,” now in a “having done” shape instead of the infinitive -ਣਾ one. Literally: “having done a kindness.” Name the item, add this, and the request is complete — no separate verb for “give” needed.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

pāṇī comes from Sanskrit **pānīya**, “that which is to be drunk,” built on **pā-**, “to drink.” That root is Indo-European **peh₃(i)-*, and English holds two disguised pieces of it: **potion** and **poison**, both through Latin *potare*, “to drink” — a poison is, etymologically, just a drink gone wrong. Greek made the same root into *sympotēs*, “one who drinks together,” which English keeps as **symposium**.

Pāṇī is a noun, and it has no room for a liker or a drinker built into it — the same shape of gap ਪਸੰਦ left for you to fill with ਮੈਨੂੰ. Ask ਮੈਨੂੰ ਪਾਣੀ ਪਸੰਦ ਹੈ, “I like water,” and you are running last chapter’s grammar on this chapter’s first noun.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **pāṇī** — water
- *Say it:* **pāṇī, kirpā karke.** — water, please
- *Match:* **karke** against **madad karnā**’s own **kar-** root
- *Trace it:* **pā-** “to drink” → **pāṇī**, and → **potion, poison, symposium**
- *Run through:* **mainū pāṇī pasand hai**, then **pāṇī, kirpā karke** — liking and requesting, side by side

Before you move on

Ask for water politely. (*Pāṇī, kirpā karke.*) What does *karke* share with *madad karnā*? (The same **kar-** root, “to do.”) Which two English words for a drink, and one for a whole gathering of them,

share *pāṇī*'s root? (**Potion, poison, symposium.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: ਪਾਣੀ; Wiktionary: ਕਿਰਪਾ.

10.2 ਚਾਹ — the ਚ that is not a consonant

Pāṇī, kirpā karke — water, please. The next drink uses the exact same pattern, and its spelling hides a tone you have not met in a noun yet.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਚਾਹ — *cāh* — tea

ਚਾਹ, ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ। — *cāh, kirpā karke.* — Tea, please.

The letters in this word

ਚਾਹ is spelled with a final ਚ, but that ਚ is not said as a consonant. Chapter 8 showed a *jh* losing its breath and leaving a **high, falling** pitch on the vowel before it — falling, because more of the word still followed. Here nothing follows: ਚਾਹ is one syllable, so the pitch has nowhere to fall *to*. It simply stays **high**: *cāh*, level and high from the vowel to the end of the word.

Gurmukhi has no separate tone mark. A trailing ਚ that is not pronounced is, in practice, how the script writes this tone — the same way ਗ਼'s dot writes a borrowed sound. Say ਖਾਣਾ *khāṇā* again, flat, then ਚਾਹ *cāh*, high: two words that both end their vowel clean, one levelled and one not.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਚਾਹ is a loanword — unlike **pāṇī**, which Punjabi has owned since Sanskrit. It came through Classical Persian **čā**, from Mandarin Chinese **chá**: the **overland** route, out through Central Asia and Persia, the same road that gave Hindi-Urdu *chāy*, Russian *chai*, and Turkish *çay*. Chinese merchants on the coast spoke a different dialect, Hokkien, where the same word is *tê* — carried by sea into Dutch and then English **tea**, French *thé*, German *Tee*. One Chinese word, two pronunciations, sorted by whether a language met it on a caravan route or a ship's deck.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **cāh** — tea — high and level, not falling
- *Run through:* both requests — **pāṇī, kirpā karke; cāh, kirpā karke**
- *Contrast:* **khāṇā**, flat; **cāh**, high
- *Trace it:* Chinese *chá* → Persian *čā* → ਚਾਹ, the overland road
- *Recall:* what ਮੈਨੂੰ ... ਪਸੰਦ ਹੈ does to the thing you like

Before you move on

Did *cāh* come by land or by sea? (**Land** — through Persian, from Mandarin.) Why is *cāh*'s tone level instead of falling, unlike *samajhṇā*'s? (**Nothing follows the vowel** — the word ends right there.) What does *cāh*'s final ਚ actually mark, if not the sound *h*? (**The tone itself.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: ਚਾਹ; Wiktionary: chai.

10.3 ਦੁੱਧ — a third request, and a tone that stays away

ਪਣੀ carried no tone; ਚਾਹ carried a level high one. This word settles which is the ordinary case.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਦੁੱਧ — *dudh* — **milk**

ਦੁੱਧ, ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ। — *dudh, kirpā karke.* — **Milk, please.**

The letters in this word

ਦ *d*, ੁ short *u*, then the ੱ *addak* doubling the consonant that follows — the same mark you already read in ਰੱਬ — and ਧ *dh*, the breathy *d* from ਪੰਨਵਾਦ. ਦੁੱਧ is said exactly as spelled: *dudh*, flat, no tone. Its breathy ਧ never lost its breath — it is still a full consonant, the way ਖ stayed a full consonant in *khāṇā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

dudh is inherited from Sanskrit **dugdha**, “that which has been milked” — grammatically a passive participle, built on the verb **duh-**, “to milk.” Its Proto-Indo-European root meant something close to “to produce, to be of use,” but the trail to any secure English word breaks there; this lesson claims none.

That gives you the chapter’s first honest sort: **pāṇī** and **dudh** are both inherited straight from Sanskrit, with a known root behind each; **cāh** is a loan from Chinese. Three requests, two different kinds of history.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **dudh**, **kirpā karke** — milk, please
- *Run through:* all three requests so far — **pāṇī**, **cāh**, **dudh**, each with *kirpā karke*
- *Sort:* inherited (**pāṇī**, **dudh**) against loaned (**cāh**)
- *Name:* the mark that doubles a consonant, and one earlier word that used it

Before you move on

Ask for milk politely. (*Dudh, kirpā karke.*) What does *dugdha* mean, literally? (“**That which has been milked.**”) Does *dudh* carry a tone? (**No** — its breathy ष is still fully pronounced.)

Sources: Wiktionary: दुध; Wiktionary: Sanskrit dugdha.

10.4 ਰੋਟੀ — a request pattern, run four times

Three drinks, one pattern: **pāṇī**, **cāh**, **dudh**, each followed by *kirpā karke*. The fourth request is food, not drink, and it closes the chapter on a letter this book has never properly taught.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਰੋਟੀ — *roṭī* — bread

ਰੋਟੀ, ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ। — *roṭī, kirpā karke.* — Bread, please.

The letters in this word

र *r*, े the *o* sign, then ढ — a retroflex *ṭ*, tongue curled back and stopping the air rather than letting it through. Chapter 3 named the whole ढ-ढ-ढ series in passing, while teaching ठीक's ठ; this is the first time ढ itself has carried a word. Then ी long *ī*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

roṭī is inherited from Sanskrit **roṭikā**, “a kind of bread.” That much is certain. What *roṭikā* itself comes from is not: the standard comparative dictionaries weigh an unattested root meaning “to strike against” against another meaning “to crush,” and neither wins. That gives this chapter its own three-way sort: **pāṇī** and **dudh** are inherited straight from Sanskrit with a known root behind each; **cāh** is a loan, traceable to Mandarin by a known road; **roṭī** is inherited too, but its own root is where recorded history simply stops.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **roṭī**, **kirpā karke** — bread, please
- *Run through:* all four requests — **pāṇī**, **cāh**, **dudh**, **roṭī**, each with *kirpā karke*
- *Sort:* inherited with a known root (**pāṇī**, **dudh**), loaned (**cāh**), inherited with an unknown root (**roṭī**)
- *Name:* which earlier chapter first mentioned the ढ-ढ-ढ series

Before you move on

Does *roṭikā*'s own root have a settled answer? (**No** — the dictionaries disagree and leave it open.) Run all four requests from this chapter. (*Pāṇī*, *cāh*, *dudh*, *roṭī*, each with *kirpā karke*.) Which one carries a tone, and what kind? (**Cāh** — high and level.) Sources: Wiktionary: रोटी; Wiktionary: Sanskrit roṭikā.

Chapter 11

Friend, Family, Brother, and Sister

Modes: ੲ eyes (4) ੴ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a friend, a family, a brother, and a sister in Punjabi, split ਪਰਿਵਾਰ into its two Sanskrit pieces, and hear the same low tone open both ਭਰਾ and ਭੈਣ even though only one of the two is truly a cousin of its English counterpart.

The chapter closes on ਭੈਣ, said pàin with the same initial-bh-to-low-tone shift as ਭਰਾ: the reader produces ਦੇਸਤ, ਪਰਿਵਾਰ, ਭਰਾ and ਭੈਣ, states that ਭਰਾ is the unbroken PIE cousin of brother while ਭੈਣ descends from bhaginī and is NOT a cousin of sister, and names the tone rule’s low-tone, word-initial case for the first time on a noun rather than a verb.

11.1 ਦੇਸਤ — the one you chose

Four things you can ask for — pāṇī, cāh, dudh, roṭī. This chapter turns from things to people, starting with the one Chapter 2’s ਤੂੰ was really for.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਦੇਸਤ — dost — friend

The letters in this word

ਦ *d*, ੋ the *o* sign, ਸ *s*, ਤ *t*. Every letter already yours, from ਦੋ, “two,” and ਸਤਿ, “truth.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दोस्त is **Persian**, not Sanskrit — borrowed from Classical Persian **dōst**, from Old Persian **dauštā**. Its root is Proto-Indo-European, meaning roughly “**to taste, to choose**.” Latin took the taste sense and left English **gusto** and **disgust**, both through *gustare*. Germanic took the choosing sense and left Old English *cēosan*, modern English **choose**. Persian took a third path: the “chosen” one became the word for a friend.

So **dost** sits beside **roṭī** as this book’s second honest gap: **roṭī**’s own root is lost to time; **dost**’s is not lost, but it belongs to Persian, not to the Sanskrit line most of your nouns so far have followed.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **dost** — friend
- *Trace it:* PIE “taste, choose” → Persian **dost**, and → English **choose**, **gusto**, **disgust**
- *Sort:* **dost** Persian, **pāṇī** and **dudh** and **roṭī** Sanskrit-line
- *Run through:* all four requests from last chapter, once more, for speed

Before you move on

Give the word for “friend.” (*Dost*.) What did its Persian root originally mean? (**To taste, to choose**.) Name two English words, from two different routes, that share that root. (**Choose**; **gusto** or **disgust**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: दोस्त; Etymonline: gusto.

11.2 परिवार — what surrounds you

दोस्त (*dost*) named one person, chosen. This word names the group you never chose at all.

You’ll want to know first — one word

परिवार — *parivār* — family

The letters in this word

प *p*, र *r*, ि short *i*, व *v* — the same व you read in वेष्ट — ा long *ā*, र *r* again. *Pa-ri-vā-r*, four syllables, no new letter in any of them.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

परिवार comes straight from Sanskrit **parivāra**, and unlike **dost** or **roṭī**, this one splits cleanly into two working pieces: **pari-**, “around,” plus **vr̥-**, “to cover, to surround.” A *parivāra* is, word for word, what encloses you — the same **pari-** that opens *parikramā*, a walk made *around* something sacred, and a **vr̥-** that also sits inside *varṇa*, “covering” — the word Sanskrit used for both colour and social class. Unlike **dost**, this is Sanskrit through and through. Unlike **roṭī**, its root is not a mystery — you can point at both halves and say what each one meant on its own.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **parivār** — family
- *Split:* **pari-** “around” + **vr̥-** “to cover” → **parivār**
- *Sort:* **dost** Persian, **roṭī** Sanskrit-but-unknown-root, **parivār** Sanskrit-and-transparent
- *Name:* one other Sanskrit word built on **pari-** or **vr̥-**

Before you move on

Give the word for “family.” (*Parivār*.) Split it into its two Sanskrit pieces and say what each meant. (**Pari-**, “around”; **vr̥-**, “to cover.”) Which of this chapter’s two words so far has a root you can point at, and which does not? (*Parivār* does; *dost* is Persian, a different question entirely.)
Sources: Wiktionary: Sanskrit/Hindi *parivār*.

11.3 त्र — a breathy letter you have not met yet

Kòrā the horse dipped and rose because its old ॡ lost its breath at the **start** of the word. This chapter’s word does the same

thing, with a different consonant, and it is not a verb this time
— it is somebody you know.

You'll want to know first — one word

भर — *bharā* — brother

The letters in this word

भ — new: the fourth letter of the *p*-row, once *bha*, a *b* said with a breathy voice. Then र *r*, ा long *ā*.

The letters in this word

Chapter 7 showed word-initial ॡ losing its breath and leaving a low, rising pitch — *kòṛā*. ॢ is the same story with a different letter: said at the front of a word, its breath is gone too, and what is left is a plain, voiceless **p**, plus a **low** tone on the vowel after it.

भर is therefore not said *bharā*. It is said **prā** — *p*, not *bh*, and low on the first vowel. Spelling keeps the old consonant; speech keeps only its pitch.

position in the word	old sound	what survives
initial (<i>bh</i> -, <i>gh</i> - ...)	breathy voice	low tone, consonant plain
medial (<i>-jh</i> -, <i>-ḍh</i> - ...)	breathy voice	high, falling tone
final, nothing after	any lost breath	high, level tone

Three positions, three outcomes, and you have now met a word for each.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

bharā is inherited from Sanskrit **bhrātṛ**, root Indo-European **b^hréh₂tēr*. This is one of the cleanest cognate sets in the family: Sanskrit *bhrātṛ*, English **brother**, Latin *frāter*, Greek *phrātēr*, Russian *brat* — every one of them the same word, by ordinary sound change, in every branch, no borrowing anywhere. Where **parivār** kept both its Sanskrit halves intact, **bharā** shows what centuries of everyday wear does instead: the whole cluster *bhr*- thinned down to a single consonant and a tone.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bharā** as it is said — *prā*, low on the first vowel
- *Trace it:* PIE *b^hréh₂tēr* → Sanskrit *bhrātṛ* → **भ्रा॑**, and → English **brother**
- *Contrast:* *bharā*, worn down to a tone, against *parivār*, kept whole
- *Run through:* the three-position tone table, one word for each row

Before you move on

How is **भ्रा॑** actually said? (*Prā* — *p*, not *bh*, low tone.) Which English word is the very same word, by unbroken descent? (**Brother**.) Name the three positions this book's tone rule now covers, and one word for each. (Initial — *bharā*, low; medial — *samajhṇā*, falling; final — *cāh*, level high.)
Sources: Wiktionary: **भ्रा॑**; Wiktionary: *b^hréh₂tēr*.

11.4 भ्रै — the same tone, a different family tree

Say **भ्रा॑** the way it is actually said — *prā*, low. This chapter's last word starts with the same letter and the same tone. Whether it shares brother's family tree is a separate question.

You'll want to know first — one word

भ्रै — *bhaiṇ* — **sister**

Said **pàin** — the same **भ्र** → **p** + **low tone** shift as **भ्रा॑**, now on a different vowel, closed by the curled-back **ṇ** you already read in **जान्**.

The letters in this word

भ्र *bh*, already yours from *bharā* — the second word in this book to use it. **ै** the *ai*-sign, from **ऐ**. **ṇ** retroflex *n*. Three letters, none of them new, and the tone is the same rule as last lesson, run again.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

भैष् is inherited from Sanskrit **bhaginī**, built on **bhaga-**, “a share, a portion” — a sister, etymologically, as one who holds a share. That root is Indo-Aryan, not a straight PIE kinship term: the old Proto-Indo-European word for “sister,” **swésōr*, is exactly what gives English **sister** — and Sanskrit simply stopped using it, replacing it with this one instead.

So भार and भैष् are not a matched pair the way English *brother* and *sister* feel like one. *Bharā* is the unbroken PIE cousin of *brother*. *Bhaiṇ* is a homegrown Indo-Aryan replacement, unrelated in root to *sister* — even though both now open with the identical *bh-become-p-plus-low-tone* sound, purely by coincidence of which consonant each word once started with.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bhaiṇ** as it is said — *pàṇ*, low tone
- *Contrast:* *bharā* — true PIE cousin of *brother*; *bhaiṇ* — unrelated to *sister*, despite the matching tone
- *Run through:* all four people-words — **dost**, **parivār**, **bharā**, **bhaiṇ**
- *Sort:* Persian (**dost**), Sanskrit-transparent (**parivār**), Sanskrit-cognate (**bharā**), Sanskrit-but-not-cognate (**bhaiṇ**)

Before you move on

Give the word for “sister,” and how it is actually said. (*Bhaiṇ*; *pàṇ*, low tone.) Is *bhaiṇ* the same word as English *sister*, the way *bharā* is the same word as *brother*? (**No** — Sanskrit replaced the old PIE sister-word with *bhaginī*, “a share-holder.”) Run this chapter’s four people-words and what each one’s history is. (*Dost* Persian; *parivār* Sanskrit and transparent; *bharā* Sanskrit and an unbroken cousin; *bhaiṇ* Sanskrit but not a cousin of *sister*.)

Sources: Wiktionary: भैष्; Wiktionary: swésōr.

Chapter 12

Eye, Ear, Mouth, and Nose

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the eye, ear, mouth, and nose in Punjabi, tell a doubled consonant that survived from one that vanished into tone, and clear up the false friend ਕੰਨ shares in spelling, but not in root, with ਕਰਨਾ.

The chapter closes on ਨੱਕ, completing the face: the reader produces ਅੱਖ, ਕੰਨ, ਮੂੰਹ and ਨੱਕ, names ਅੱਖ and ਨੱਕ as unbroken PIE cousins of eye and nose that kept their doubled consonants and so never traded a sound for a tone, and states that ਮੂੰਹ alone among the four carries a level high tone, the same one first heard in ਚਾਹ.

12.1 ਅੱਖ — the eye that kept both its consonants

ਭੈਣ closed a chapter about people. This chapter checks on how someone *is* — starting with the parts of the body a friend might actually ask about.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਅੱਖ — *akkh* — eye

The letters in this word

ਅ, the bare vowel-carrier for *a*, then the ੱ *addak* — the same doubling mark from ਰੱਬ and ਦੁੱਧ — over ਖ *kh*. Read together: *a-kkh*, the *k* held and released with real force, not a tone standing in for it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

akkh is inherited from Prakrit **akkhi**, from Sanskrit **akṣi**, “eye,” from Proto-Indo-Iranian **Hákšī*, from Proto-Indo-European **h₃ók^ws* — unbroken all the way to English **eye** itself.

Every tone you have met so far came from a consonant that **lost** something — its breathy voice, or the whole of itself. **अ** here loses nothing: Sanskrit *akṣi*’s consonant cluster became a **doubled** *kkh* in Middle Indo-Aryan, and Punjabi still says both halves in full. That is exactly why *akkh* is flat — the addak mark you are reading is the opposite move from a tone mark: it doubles a sound that survives, where a lost sound is what leaves a tone behind. Hindi took a different road with the same word, smoothing the cluster down into a nasal vowel, *āñkh* — no doubling, no tone, a third outcome entirely.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **akkh** — eye — the *kkh* held, not a tone
- *Trace it:* PIE *h₃ók^ws* → Sanskrit *akṣi* → **अक्ष**, and → English **eye**
- *Contrast:* a doubled consonant that survives (*akkh*) against one that vanished into tone (*bharā*’s *bh*)
- *Name:* two other words that used the addak mark

Before you move on

Give the word for “eye.” (*Akkh.*) Which English word is the same word by unbroken descent? (**Eye.**) Does *akkh* carry a tone? (**No** — its doubled *kkh* survived in full, unlike a consonant that lost its breath.)

Sources: Wiktionary: **अक्ष**; Wiktionary: Sanskrit *akṣi*.

12.2 कर्ण — a false friend hiding in plain sight

Say *madad karnā*, “to do a favour of help,” and pull its stem apart: **kar-**. Watch that same string of sounds turn up again, meaning something it has nothing to do with.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਕੰਨ — *kann* — ear

The letters in this word

ਕ *k*, ੰ the *ṭippi* nasal, ਨ *n* — and the vowel is nasalized where ਅੱਖ doubled a consonant instead. *Ka-nn*, with the doubling this time carried by the nasal mark rather than the addak.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਕੰਨ is inherited from Sanskrit **karṇa**, “ear.” Its own root beyond Sanskrit has never been securely traced — one guess ties it to a word for “twisting” or “winding,” another to a word for “point,” and no source picks a winner.

Here is the trap: **karṇa** looks exactly like it is hiding ਕਰਨਾ *karnā*, “to do,” the very verb inside ਮਦਦ ਕਰਨਾ. It is not. *Karnā*, “to do,” traces to a completely different Proto-Indo-European root, **k^wer-*. *Karṇa*, “ear,” does not connect to it at all — the resemblance is a coincidence of sound, the kind every language accumulates, and Punjabi keeps both words close enough in spelling that a learner has to be told, not left to guess.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **kann** — ear
- *State:* is *kann* related to *karnā*, “to do”? (No — a coincidence of sound.)
- *Run through:* **akkh**, **kann** — eye, ear
- *Recall:* *madad karnā*’s own **kar-**, and how it differs from *kann*’s

Before you move on

Give the word for “ear.” (*Kann*.) Does it share a root with *karnā*, “to do”? (**No** — different Proto-Indo-European roots entirely.)

Name the two body words so far. (*Akkh*, *kann*.)

Sources: Wiktionary: ਕੰਨ; Wiktionary: Sanskrit karṇa.

12.3 ਮੂੰਹ — a consonant that wore all the way down to a tone

ਚਾਰ's final ਚ was not really a consonant — it marked a level high tone, because the word ended right there. This word ends the same way, from a consonant that used to be something else entirely. And unlike ਕੰਨ, which only *looks* like it hides ਕਰਨਾ inside it, this word hides no false friend at all.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਮੂੰਹ — *mūnh* — **mouth**, also **face**

The letters in this word

ਮ *m*, ੂ long *ū*, ੰ the nasal *ṭippi*, ਚ — again not spoken as *h*, marking the same level high tone you first read in ਚਾਰ: *mūh*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

mūnh is inherited from Sanskrit **mukha**, “face, mouth” — Punjabi also kept the same word a second time, whole, as the learned borrowing ਮੁਖ *mukh*, the way it kept both ਪਸੰਦ and its own inherited relatives side by side before.

On the inherited path, *mukha*'s middle **kh** did not simply vanish. Middle Indo-Aryan first softened intervocalic *kh* down to a plain **h** — a regular, well-worn move, nothing to do with the breathy-voiced letters that gave you *bharā*'s low tone or *samajhṇā*'s falling one. Punjabi then lost **that** *h* too, the same way it lost *cāh*'s Persian-final one, and let its pitch land on the vowel before it: level and high, because — exactly as in *cāh* — nothing follows it in the word.

So *mūnh* and *cāh* reach a level high tone from different histories — one from a worn-down *kh*, one from a borrowed word's own *h* — and arrive at the identical sound.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **mūnh** — mouth, face — level and high
- *Match:* *mūnh*'s tone against *cāh*'s
- *Trace it:* Sanskrit *mukha* → *kh* softens to *h* → *h* is lost → ਮੂੰਹ

- *Name*: the learned twin of *mūnh* that kept the whole word intact

Before you move on

What tone does *mūnh* carry, and which earlier word — not a body word, but the same pattern — first showed it? (**Level high**; **cāh**, tea, from Chapter 10.) What softened before Punjabi lost it entirely in *mukha* → *mūnh*? (**Kh**, first to plain **h**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: ਮੂੰਹ; Wiktionary: Sanskrit mukha.

12.4 ਨੱਕ — the whole face, run back

ਅੱਖ, ਕੰਨ, ਮੂੰਹ — eye, ear, mouth. One more completes the face, and it closes the chapter on the cleanest English cousin this book has found yet.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਨੱਕ — *nakk* — nose

The letters in this word

ਨ *n*, ੱ the addak, ਕ *k* — the same doubling mark as ਅੱਖ, and for the same reason: nothing here was ever breathy, so nothing here traded itself for a tone.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

nakk is inherited from Old Punjabi **naku**, and its root is Proto-Indo-European **neh₂s-* — unbroken, all the way to English **nose** itself, Latin *nāsus*, and Lithuanian *nósis*. Like *akkh*, *nakk* needed no ship and no loanword to reach you, only the ordinary work of sound change and a doubled consonant that held its ground.

Run the whole face and its tone table: **akkh** flat, doubled; **kann** flat, nasal, no relation at all to *karnā*; **mūnh** level and high, a worn-down *kh*; **nakk** flat, doubled, the clean cousin of *nose*. Two of the four carry no tone because their old consonants survived whole; one carries a level high tone because its consonant vanished entirely; none of the four carries the low or falling tones you met on verbs and on *bharā* — those belong to words that opened or closed with a breathy voice, and

nothing here ever did.

Your turn

- *Say it:* all four face words — **akkh**, **kann**, **mūnh**, **nakk**
- *Trace it:* PIE *neh₂s-* → **𑀓𑀭𑀮**, and → English **nose**
- *Sort:* which of the four carry a tone, and which do not
- *Name:* the doubled-consonant pair, **akkh** and **nakk**

Before you move on

Give the word for “nose.” (*Nakk*.) Which English word is the same word by unbroken descent? (**Nose**.) Name the four face words and which one carries a tone. (*Akkh*, *kann*, *mūnh*, *nakk*; only *mūnh*, level and high.)

Sources: Wiktionary: **𑀓𑀭𑀮**.

Chapter 13

Heart and Head

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the heart and the head in Punjabi, tell that ਦਿਲ is Punjabi's one borrowed body word against four inherited ones, and trace ਸਿਰ to the same root as English horn rather than English head.

The tranche closes on ਸਿਰ: the reader produces all six body words from this tranche, states that ਸਿਰ's real English cousin is horn, not head, and that its resemblance to Persian sar is convergence from a shared Proto-Indo-Iranian ancestor rather than a loan — the opposite case from ਦਿਲ, which genuinely was borrowed from Persian despite sharing the same deep Indo-European root as English heart.

13.1 ਦਿਲ — the one body word that is not Sanskrit

ਅੱਖ, ਕੰਨ, ਮੂੰਹ, ਨੱਕ — four body words, all inherited from Sanskrit. This one breaks the pattern the same way ਦੇਸ਼ once did.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਦਿਲ — *dil* — heart

The letters in this word

ਦ *d*, ਿ short *i*, ਲ *l*. Every letter already yours, from ਦੁੱਧ and ਲੈਣਾ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਦਿਲ is **Persian**, borrowed the way ਦੋਸਤ was — Punjabi’s everyday word for “heart” is not the word Sanskrit handed down. Sanskrit’s own word, **hṛdaya**, exists in Punjabi too, but only as a formal, literary borrowing; ordinary speech reaches for *dil*.

And yet *dil* is not a stranger to Sanskrit’s word. Both descend from the same Proto-Indo-European root, **kerd-*, “heart” — Persian’s branch carried it to *dil*, Sanskrit’s branch carried it to *hṛdaya*, and a third branch carried it, unbroken, to English **heart** itself. Three languages, three shapes, one ancestor. What makes *dil* worth flagging is not the deep root — that root is shared honestly — but the fact that Punjabi took its *everyday* word for heart by borrowing sideways from Persian, rather than by inheriting straight down from Sanskrit the way *akkh* and *nakk* did.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **dil** — heart
- *Trace it*: PIE *kerd-* → Persian *dil* / Sanskrit *hṛdaya* / English **heart**, three branches
- *Contrast*: *dil*, borrowed, against *akkh* and *nakk*, inherited
- *Recall*: the other Persian loan this book has taught for a person you know (**dost**)

Before you move on

Is *dil* inherited from Sanskrit or borrowed from Persian?

(**Borrowed**, from Persian — Sanskrit’s own word, *hṛdaya*, stays formal.) What single Proto-Indo-European root sits behind *dil*, Sanskrit *hṛdaya*, and English *heart*, all three? (**Kerd-*.)

Sources: Wiktionary: ਦਿਲ; Wiktionary: Persian dil.

13.2 ਸਿਰ — a cousin of “horn,” and a twin nobody borrowed

ਦਿਲ broke the pattern — borrowed, where every other body word was inherited. This last word restores the pattern, and closes the

tranche on its most surprising cousin yet. On the way, say **ਭਰਾ** and **ਭੈਣ** once more, low-toned, the way this book's other loan-versus-inheritance pair opened it.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਸਿਰ — *sir* — head

The letters in this word

ਸ *s*, ਿ short *i*, ਰ *r*. Every letter already familiar, from **ਸਤਿ** and **ਮੇਰਾ**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਸਿਰ is inherited, back to Proto-Indo-European **kerh₂-*, “head, horn.” That is genuinely surprising: English **head** comes from an entirely different, unrelated root, **kaput-*. *Sir*'s real English cousin is **horn** — the same **kerh₂-* that gave Latin *cornū* and the Greek word for “head,” *karēnon*. A head, on this root's evidence, was once named for whatever stood up highest and hardest on it.

One more thing *sir* does, that no word in this book has done before: it looks identical to Persian **sar**, “head” — and unlike *dil*, that is **not** a loan. Persian and Sanskrit are sister branches of Proto-Indo-Iranian, and each inherited **kerh₂-* on its own, straight down its own line. *Dil* is Punjabi reaching sideways into Persian for a word it did not otherwise have. *Sir* only looks like the same kind of borrowing; it is a twin by shared birth, not by loan — closing this tranche the same way Chapter 6 closed on *panj*, two branches independently arriving at one shape. Running the whole face and the two words beyond it: **akkh**, **kann**, **mūnh**, **nakk** are all inherited and tone-marked only where a consonant was lost outright; **dil** is the one loanword; **sir** is inherited, and its resemblance to Persian is convergence, exactly like *panj*'s.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **sir** — head
- *State*: *sir*'s real English cousin (**horn**, not **head**)
- *Contrast*: *sir* and Persian *sar* — look-alikes by shared ancestry, not by loan; *dil* — a genuine loan

- *Run through:* all six body words from this tranche — **akkh**, **kann**, **mūnh**, **nakk**, **dil**, **sir**

Before you move on

Give the word for “head.” (*Sir*.) Which English word is its real cousin — *head*, or *horn*? (**Horn**.) Is *sir*’s resemblance to Persian *sar* a loan, the way *dil* is? (**No** — both inherited the same root separately, the way *panj* and Persian *panj* once did.) Name all six body words from this tranche. (*Akkh*, *kann*, *mūnh*, *nakk*, *dil*, *sir*.) Sources: Wiktionary: सिर; Wiktionary: kerh₂-.

Chapter 14

From the Mouth of the Guru, One Piece at a Time

Modes: ✍ pen (10) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write nine Gurmukhi pieces from memory — four consonants, three vowel signs and the nasal bindi — and read the words for yes, no and the greeting by assembling them from those pieces.

The greeting assembled from five pieces the reader can each write from memory, introducing nothing new, and naming plainly the one piece of machinery still to come.

14.1 ਼ — the consonant ha

Nothing is assumed but the words you can already say. This chapter turns them into words you can read.

Script

Gurmukhi is an **abugida**: a consonant already carries a vowel, and you write a vowel mark only when you want a different one.

ੜ

That is **ha** — the consonant *h* with an **a** already inside it, the *a* of English *about*. Nobody wrote that vowel. A bare consonant is understood to carry it, and it is called the **inherent vowel**.

Now the name, because it tells you what this script is for. **Gurmukhi** means “from the mouth of the Guru.” It was standardised in the sixteenth century by Guru Angad, the second Sikh Guru, to write down what had until then been recited — and that origin is why it is a **tidier** script than its neighbours: it was designed in one go, for one purpose, rather than drifting into shape over centuries.

Look at the top. There is a **head-line** across it, as in Devanagari, and in running text it joins up so a word appears to hang from a line. Gujarati is the sister that erases this line; Gurmukhi keeps it.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ਿ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What vowel does a bare consonant carry? (**a** — nobody writes it.)
 What does *Gurmukhi* mean? (**From the mouth of the Guru.**)
 And is the head-line there? (**Yes** — kept, not erased.)
 Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.2 ਿ — the vowel sign that replaces the inherent a

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

To get a different vowel you **replace** the inherent one, with a mark called a **mātrā**.

ਿ

A single upright stroke standing to the **right** of its consonant, dropping from the head-line. Attached, it swaps the short *a* for **ā**, the *a* of English *father*.

ਹ + ਿ → ਹਾ

hā. One beat — a mātrā changes the vowel, it never adds a beat.
 You are one mark away from a word.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ੋ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What does a mātrā do to the inherent vowel? (**Replaces** it.) Where does this one sit? (To the **right**.) And does it add a beat? (**No**.)
Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.3 ੋ — a dot above the line that nasalises the vowel

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

Here is a mark that is not a vowel at all.

ੌ

This is the **bindi**, a dot sitting **above the head-line**. It does not change which vowel you say. It says: **send that vowel through your nose**.

English does this constantly and never writes it. Say *bad*, then say *ban* — the vowel in the second is nasalised before you ever reach the *n*. Punjabi writes what English leaves implicit.

ਗ + ੌ → ਗੰ

hāṁ — and that is **yes**, the word you have been saying since your first lesson.

Nasalisation is meaning-bearing here. It is not an accent or a flourish; drop the dot and you have a different word. That is why the script spends a character on it.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ੌ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What does the bindi do? (**N**asalises the vowel — sends it through the nose.) Does it change which vowel you say? (**N**o.) And what word did it complete? (ਫ਼ੀ — *hāmī*, “yes”).

Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.4 ਠ — the consonant na

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ਠ

na — the *n* of English *net*, with the inherent **a** riding along.

No new machinery. Every rule you already hold applies to it unchanged, and that is the point of learning the system rather than the words: **new shapes are coming; new rules are not.**

Your turn

- *Write it:* ਠ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What vowel is inside ਠ when nothing is attached? (**a**.) How many new rules did this lesson add? (**None**.)

Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.5 ੀ — a second mātrā

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ੴ

ī, the long *ee* of English *see*. Like the first mātrā it stands to the right, but it carries a curve that rises and **hooks back over the head-line**.

Now build with everything you have:

ਨ + ਹ + ੀ + ਂ → ਨਹੀਂ

na-hīm — **no**. Two consonants, one mātrā, one nasal dot.

Both answers to a yes-or-no question are now readable:

ਹਾਂ ਨਹੀਂ

That is the arithmetic of an abugida: consonants and mātrās **multiply**, so a handful of pieces reaches a large number of syllables very quickly.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ੀ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What is ਨਹੀਂ? (**No**.) How many pieces is it built from? (**Four**.) And what is the dot doing at the end? (**Nasalising** the vowel.)

Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.6 ਖ — the consonant ma

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ਖ

ma — the *m* of English *met*, plus the inherent vowel.

Three consonants. Say them in the order you met them, each with the vowel nobody wrote:

ਹ ਨ ਖ

ha, na, ma.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ਞ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

Say the three consonants you hold, each with its inherent vowel.
(*ha*, *na*, *ma*.)
Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.7 ਞ — the consonant sa

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ਞ

sa — the *s* of English *sit*, plus the inherent vowel.

Four consonants, two mātrās and a nasal dot. One shape and one mātrā left before the greeting is readable.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ਞ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What is the inherent vowel in ਞ? (**a** — *sa*.)
Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.8 ਤ — the consonant ta

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ਤ

ta — and it is not quite the English consonant.

English *t* is made with the tongue on the **ridge behind** the teeth. This one is **dental**: the tongue touches the **back of the upper teeth themselves**, further forward. It sounds softer to an English ear, and getting it right is one of the quickest ways to stop sounding foreign.

The script has a **second** t made further back, and the two are different letters in different words. This is the forward one.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ਤ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

Where does the tongue go for ਤ? (Against the **back of the upper teeth** — dental.) Is there another t? (**Yes**, one made further back.)
Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.9 ੇ — a mātrā that sits ABOVE the letter, not beside it

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ੇ

e, the vowel of English *they*. And unlike both mātrās you already hold, which stand to the right, this one sits **above** the letter, riding on the headline:

ਤ + ੇ → ਤੇ

te. Still one beat.

Where a mātrā sits is part of its identity, not a style choice. In this family of scripts a vowel sign can go right, left, above, below, or on both sides at once, and a reader learns to look **around** a consonant rather than only after it.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ੇ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

Where does this mātrā sit? (**Above** the consonant.) Does it add a beat? (**No.**)

Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

14.10 ਨਮਸਤੇ — five pieces, all of them already yours

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

Nothing new is introduced here. Every piece below is one you can write.

ਨ + ਮ + ਸ + ਤ + ੇ → ਨਮਸਤੇ

Read it the way you built it:

- ਨ — *na*, inherent vowel
- ਮ — *ma*, inherent vowel
- ਸ — *sa*, inherent vowel
- ਤੇ — *ta* with the mātrā above, making *te*

na-ma-ste. Four consonants in a row, three of them carrying the vowel nobody wrote, and one mark on the last. The greeting from your first lesson, decoded rather than recalled.

One piece of machinery is still missing, and it is worth naming rather than hiding. Some words press two consonants together with no vowel between them, and this script has a way to write that — a mark that deletes the inherent vowel and fuses the pair into one shape. You have not needed it yet. The longer Sikh greeting you already say contains one, and it is the next thing this book will teach you.

So: **four consonants, three mātrās and a nasal dot**, and with them you can read *yes*, *no* and the greeting.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ਨਮਸਤੇ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

How many new pieces were in this lesson? (**None.**) What carries the vowel in ਼, ਙ and ਞ? (**Nothing** — it is the inherent vowel.) And what is the one piece of machinery still to come? (The mark that **deletes** the inherent vowel and **joins** two consonants.) Source: Unicode Gurmukhi chart.

The Gurmukhi script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ਕ ka, ਨ na, ਮ ma — written left to right under a connecting top line.
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** ਾ ā (ਕਾ kā), ਿ i, ਿ̄ ī, ੁ u, ੁ̄ ū, ੇ e, ੋ o. A *bindi* ੱ or *tippi* ੲ nasalises the vowel.
3. **Word-initial vowels ride a carrier.** Three bearer letters — ਊ (u-series), ਐ (a-series), ਓ (i-series) — hold a vowel that starts a word: ਐ + nothing = a, ਐ̄ = ā.

Worth flagging

- **The *pair bindi* (a dot beneath).** It marks Perso-Arabic sounds Punjabi borrowed: ਸ sh, ਖ x/kh, ਜ z, ਫ f, ਗ g. The script literally *annotates* its loanwords.
- **Tone.** Punjabi is unusual among Indian languages in being *tonal* — certain letters (the old voiced-aspirates ਅ ਝ ਢ ਧ ਢ) now trigger a low or high tone on the syllable. You will pick this up by ear; the lessons flag it only where it changes a word.

Gurmukhi and the Punjabi story

Gurmukhi means “from the mouth of the Guru”: the second Sikh Guru, Angad, shaped it in the 16th century to write the community’s teachings. Punjabi is **Indo-Aryan** (like Hindi, Marathi, Bengali — all from Sanskrit), spoken across Punjab in India and Pakistan; in Pakistan it is more often written in a Perso-Arabic script (*Shahmukhi*), a mirror of Punjabi’s own two inheritances. The lessons trace both — the Sanskrit and the Persian.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

ਅੱਖ *akkh*

eye — a doubled consonant that survived whole, so it never had a tone to lose
Introduced in Chapter 12.

ਆਉਣਾ *āuṇā*

to come — “go” with “toward” glued on the front, and the “go” half is English
come
Introduced in Chapter 7.

ਭੈਣ *bhaiṇ*

sister — the same low tone as brother, but not the same family of words
Introduced in Chapter 11.

ਭਰਾ *bharā*

brother — spelled with a breathy bh, said with a plain p and a low tone
Introduced in Chapter 11.

ਚਾਹ *cāh*

tea — a word that took the overland road out of China, and a level high tone
hiding inside its own spelling
Introduced in Chapter 10.

ਦਿਲ *dil*

heart — a Persian loan, not the Sanskrit word Punjabi’s other body parts have all used
Introduced in Chapter 13.

ਦੋਸਤ *dost*

friend — a Persian word that literally means “the one you chose”
Introduced in Chapter 11.

ਦੁੱਧ *dudh*

milk — “that which has been milked,” said flat, with no tone at all
Introduced in Chapter 10.

ਹੋਣਾ *hoṇā*

to be — the infinitive that sounds nothing like ਹੈ, because two ancient verbs are braided inside it

Introduced in Chapter 7.

ਇੱਕ ਦੇ ਤਿੰਨ ਚਾਰ ਪੰਜ *ikk do tinn chār panj*

one to five — meeting the panj of Punjabi as an actual number

Introduced in Chapter 6.

ਜਾਣਾ *jāṇā*

to go — and the one sound law that turns Sanskrit words into Punjabi ones

Introduced in Chapter 7.

ਜਾਣਨਾ *jāṇnā*

to know — one letter away from “to go,” and the same word as English know

Introduced in Chapter 7.

ਕੰਨ *kann*

ear — a word that looks like it hides “to do” inside it, and does not

Introduced in Chapter 12.

ਖਾਣਾ *khāṇā*

to eat — and the letter next door that stopped being a consonant and became a tone

Introduced in Chapter 7.

ਲੈਣਾ *laiṇā*

to take — a verb that lost a whole consonant on the way here

Introduced in Chapter 9.

ਲਿਖਣਾ *likhṇā*

to write — from a root meaning to scratch, which is how three unrelated languages named it

Introduced in Chapter 8.

ਮਦਦ ਕਰਨਾ *madad karnā*

to help — literally “to do help,” and the help half is Arabic

Introduced in Chapter 9.

ਮੂੰਹ *mūnh*

mouth, face — the second word this book has found with a level high tone

Introduced in Chapter 12.

ਨੱਕ *nakk*

nose — the plainest possible cousin of the English word for the very same part

Introduced in Chapter 12.

ਪਾਣੀ *pāṇī*

water — Punjabi’s first noun for something you would actually ask for, and the phrase that asks for it politely

Introduced in Chapter 10.

ਪੜ੍ਹਨਾ *parhṇā*

to read — and in the language it came from, reading meant saying it out loud
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ਪਰਿਵਾਰ *parivār*

family — literally “what surrounds you,” built from two Sanskrit pieces you can pull apart
Introduced in Chapter 11.

ਪਸੰਦ *pasand*

liked, pleasing — a Persian noun, not a verb, in the one sentence that will not let you be its subject
Introduced in Chapter 9.

ਪੁੱਛਣਾ *puchhṇā*

to ask — cousin to the Persian word for asking, and neither borrowed it from the other
Introduced in Chapter 9.

ਰੋਟੀ *roṭī*

bread — the fourth request, and the retroflex letter this book only mentioned in passing until now
Introduced in Chapter 10.

ਸਮਝਣਾ *samajhṇā*

to understand — from a root meaning “to wake up,” and the word carries a tone
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ਸਿਰ *sir*

head — a cousin of English horn, not of English head, and an unborrowed twin of Persian sar
Introduced in Chapter 13.

ਸੋਚਣਾ *sochṇā*

to think — a verb that started out meaning to burn, and then to grieve
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ਵੇਖਣਾ *vekhṇā*

to see — built on the old word for the eye itself, the root behind eye, optic, and window
Introduced in Chapter 7.

ਕੀ

what
Introduced in Chapter 2.

ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ

it’s nothing / no problem / you’re welcome
Introduced in Chapter 3.

ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ

to work (lit. “work-do”)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

ਕਿਵੇਂ

how

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ

pleased to meet you (lit. “happiness happened”)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ਠੀਕ

fine, well — and the reply “ਮੈਂ ਠੀਕ ਹਾਂ”

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ਤੂੰ / ਤੁਸੀਂ

you (familiar / respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ?

how are you? (respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ?

what’s your name?

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ਧੰਨਵਾਦ

thank you (Sanskritic) (dhannavād)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ਨਾਂ

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ਨਮਸਤੇ

hello (general, pan-Indian) (namaste)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ਫਿਰ

again, then

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ

we’ll meet again (goodbye)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ਬੋਲਣਾ

to speak

Introduced in Chapter 5.

ਮੈਂ

I

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ ਹਾਂ

I speak Punjabi (gendered)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

ਮੇਰਾ

my

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ... ਹੈ

my name is...

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ

(we) will meet

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ

goodbye (lit. “God [be your] keeper”)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ਰਹਿਣਾ

to live, to stay

Introduced in Chapter 5.

ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ

thank you (Perso-Arabic) (shukrīā)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ

hello / goodbye, the Sikh greeting (sat srī akāl)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ਹੈ

is

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ਹਾਂ / ਨਹੀਂ

yes / no (hāṃ / nahīṃ)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 6

6.1 *Why two branches both arrived at panj*
Was Punjabi panj borrowed from Persian?

Chapter 7

7.1 ਜਾਣਨਾ — *“to know,” one letter from “to go”*
Which Punjabi verb means to know, jana or janna?

Chapter 8

8.1 ਸੋਚਣਾ — *“to think,” and it once meant “to burn”*
The Punjabi noun soch means a thought and one other thing. What?

8.2 ਸਮਝਣਾ — *“to understand,” and the tone you can hear in it*
In samajhna the jh is not heard as breath. What is heard instead?

8.3 ਪੜ੍ਹਨਾ — *“to read,” which used to mean “to say out loud”*
In the cluster rrha, where is the h written relative to the letter before it?

8.4 ਲਿਖਣਾ — *“to write,” which is scratching*
What did the Sanskrit root behind likhna mean before it meant to write?

Chapter 9

9.1 ਲੈਣਾ — *“to take,” worn down to almost nothing*

Which Sanskrit verb is *laina* worn down from?

9.2 ਪੁੱਛਣਾ — *“to ask,” and a Persian cousin that is not a loan*

What does the addak mark tell you to do to the consonant after it?

9.3 ਮਦਦ ਕਰਨਾ — *“to help,” which is two words*

Which language does the word *madad* come from originally?

9.4 ਪਸੰਦ — *Punjabi does not like things; things please Punjabi*

Type the Punjabi for ‘to me’ — the form *main* takes when it cannot be the subject.

Chapter 10

10.1 ਪਾਣੀ — *the first thing you’ll actually ask for*

Ask for water politely, in Punjabi.

10.2 ਚਾਹ — *the ਚ that is not a consonant*

Is *chaa*’s tone falling or level?

10.3 ਰੋਟੀ — *a request pattern, run four times*

Ask for bread politely, in Punjabi.

Chapter 11

11.1 ਪਰਿਵਾਰ — *what surrounds you*

parivar splits into two Sanskrit pieces meaning ‘around’ and ‘to cover’. What is the whole word’s literal sense?

11.2 ਭਰਾ — *a breathy letter you have not met yet*

bharā’s *bh* is said as which consonant, and what tone does the vowel after it carry?

11.3 ਭੈਣ — *the same tone, a different family tree*

Is *bhain* the same word as English *sister* by unbroken descent, the way *bharā* is the same word as *brother*?

Chapter 12

12.1 ਕੰਨ — *a false friend hiding in plain sight*

Does *kann*, ‘ear’, share a root with *karnā*, ‘to do’?

12.2 ਮੂੰਹ — *a consonant that wore all the way down to a tone*

What Sanskrit word does mūnh come from, and what learned Punjabi word keeps the same source intact?

12.3 ਨੱਕ — *the whole face, run back*

Name all four Punjabi face words taught in this chapter, in any order.

Chapter 13

13.1 ਦਿਲ — *the one body word that is not Sanskrit*

Is dil, Punjabi's everyday word for heart, inherited from Sanskrit or borrowed from Persian?

13.2 ਸਿਰ — *a cousin of "horn," and a twin nobody borrowed*

sir shares its Proto-Indo-European root with which English word — head, or horn?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 6

6.1 *Why two branches both arrived at pañj*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no it was not; it inherits Sanskrit pañca; it comes from Sanskrit pañca

Chapter 7

7.1 *ज्ञात — “to know,” one letter from “to go”*

Answer: janna

Also accepted: jāṇnā; jannaa; jaanna

Chapter 8

8.1 *मेचट — “to think,” and it once meant “to burn”*

Answer: a worry

Also accepted: worry; worrying; anxiety; a worry or a care

8.2 *ममझट — “to understand,” and the tone you can hear in it*

Answer: a falling tone

Also accepted: falling tone; a falling pitch; the pitch falls; high falling tone; tone

8.3 *पडुठ — “to read,” which used to mean “to say out loud”*

Answer: underneath

Also accepted: below; under; beneath; underneath it; under it

8.4 *लिषट — “to write,” which is scratching*

Answer: to scratch

Also accepted: scratch; scrape; to scrape; scratching; scraping

Chapter 9

9.1 ਲੈਣਾ — *“to take,” worn down to almost nothing*

Answer: labhate

Also accepted: labh; labh-; labhati; sanskrit labhate

9.2 ਪੁੱਛਣਾ — *“to ask,” and a Persian cousin that is not a loan*

Answer: double it

Also accepted: double; doubles it; hold it long; lengthen it

9.3 ਮਦਦ ਕਰਨਾ — *“to help,” which is two words*

Answer: Arabic

Also accepted: from arabic; arabic via persian; arabic through persian

9.4 ਪਸੰਦ — *Punjabi does not like things; things please Punjabi*

Answer: ਮੈਨੂੰ

Also accepted: mainu; mainun; mainoo; mainū

Chapter 10

10.1 ਪਾਣੀ — *the first thing you’ll actually ask for*

Answer: ਪਾਣੀ, ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ

Also accepted: pani kirpa karke; paani, kirpa karke; pāṇī, kirpā karke; pani kirpa karke.

10.2 ਚਾਹ — *the ਚ that is not a consonant*

Answer: level

Also accepted: high level; level high; high and level; stays high

10.3 ਰੋਟੀ — *a request pattern, run four times*

Answer: ਰੋਟੀ, ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ

Also accepted: roti kirpa karke; roṭī, kirpā karke; roti, kirpa karke.

Chapter 11

11.1 ਪਰਿਵਾਰ — *what surrounds you*

Answer: what surrounds you

Also accepted: that which surrounds; surrounding; what encloses you; that which covers around

11.2 ਭਰਾ — *a breathy letter you have not met yet*

Answer: p, low tone

Also accepted: p and low; plain p, low; p, low; voiceless p and a low tone

11.3 ਭੈਣ — *the same tone, a different family tree*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no it is not; no, unrelated; no different root

Chapter 12

12.1 ਕੰਨ — *a false friend hiding in plain sight*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no it does not; no unrelated; no, coincidence

12.2 ਮੂੰਹ — *a consonant that wore all the way down to a tone*

Answer: mukha, and mukh

Also accepted: mukha and mukh; mukha; mukh; mukha, mukh

12.3 ਨੱਕ — *the whole face, run back*

Answer: akkh, kann, munh, nakk

Also accepted: akkh kann munh nakk; ਅੱਖ ਕੰਨ ਮੂੰਹ ਨੱਕ; eye ear mouth nose

Chapter 13

13.1 ਦਿਲ — *the one body word that is not Sanskrit*

Answer: borrowed from Persian

Also accepted: persian; borrowed persian; persian loan

13.2 ਸਿਰ — *a cousin of “horn,” and a twin nobody borrowed*

Answer: horn

Also accepted: horn not head; its horn

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

A

◌◌ — **a dot above the line that nasalises the vowel**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

◌◌ — **a mātrā that sits ABOVE the letter, not beside it**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

◌◌ — **a second mātrā**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

again, then ਫਿਰ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 13

B

bread — the fourth request, and the retroflex letter this book only mentioned in passing until now ਰੋਟੀ (rotī)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 49

brother — spelled with a breathy bh, said with a plain p and a low tone ਭਰਾ (bharā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 55

E

ear — a word that looks like it hides “to do” inside it, and does not ਕੰਨ (kann)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 61

eye — a doubled consonant that survived whole, so it never had a tone to lose ਅੱਖ (akkh)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 61

Eye, Ear, Mouth, and Nose

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 61

F

family — literally “what surrounds you,” built from two Sanskrit pieces you can pull apart ਪਰਿਵਾਰ (parivār)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 55

Farewells

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 13

fine, well — and the reply “ਮੈਂ ਠੀਕ ਹਾਂ” ਠੀਕ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 9

friend — a Persian word that literally means “the one you chose” ਦੋਸਤ (dost)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 55

Friend, Family, Brother, and Sister

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 55

From the Mouth of the Guru, One Piece at a Time

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 71

G

goodbye (lit. “God [be your] keeper”) ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 13

Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

head — a cousin of English horn, not of English head, and an unborrowed twin of Persian sar ਸਿਰ (sir)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 67

heart — a Persian loan, not the Sanskrit word Punjabi’s other body parts have all used ਦਿਲ (dil)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 67

Heart and Head

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 67

hello (general, pan-Indian) (namaste) ਨਮਸਤੇ

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

hello / goodbye, the Sikh greeting (sat srī akāl) ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

how ਕਿਵੇਂ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 9

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 9

how are you? (respectful) ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ?

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 9

I

I ਮੈਂ

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 9

I speak Punjabi (gendered) ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ ਹਾਂ

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 15

Introducing Yourself

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 5

is ਹੈ

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

it's nothing / no problem / you're welcome ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 9

L

liked, pleasing — a Persian noun, not a verb, in the one sentence

that will not let you be its subject ਪਸੰਦ (pasand)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 41

M

milk — “that which has been milked,” said flat, with no tone at

all ਦੁੱਧ (dudh)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 49

mouth, face — the second word this book has found with a level

high tone ਮੂੰਹ (mūnh)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 61

my ਮੇਰਾ

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

my name is... ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ... ਹੈ

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 5

N

name ਨਾਂ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

nose — the plainest possible cousin of the English word for the very same part ਨੱਕ (nakk)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 61

Numbers One to Five

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 19

O

one to five — meeting the panj of Punjabi as an actual number ਇੱਕ ਦੇ ਤਿੰਨ ਚਾਰ ਪੰਜ (ikk do tinn chār panj)

Chapter 6, p. 19

P

pleased to meet you (lit. “happiness happened”) ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

S

sister — the same low tone as brother, but not the same family of words ਭੈਣ (bhain)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 55

Six Verbs at the Core

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 23

T

Taking, Asking, Helping, and What Pleases You

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 41

tea — a word that took the overland road out of China, and a level high tone hiding inside its own spelling ਚਾਹ (cāh)

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 49

thank you (Perso-Arabic) (shukriā) ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

thank you (Sanskritic) (dhannavād) ਧੰਨਵਾਦ

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

The First Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 15

The Mind, the Page, and the Falling Tone

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 33

ਾ — the vowel sign that replaces the inherent a

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

to ask — cousin to the Persian word for asking, and neither**borrowed it from the other ਪੁੱਛਣਾ (puchhṇā)**

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 9, p. 41

to be — the infinitive that sounds nothing like ਹੈ, because two**ancient verbs are braided inside it ਹੋਣਾ (hoṇā)**

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 23

to come — “go” with “toward” glued on the front, and the “go”**half is English come ਆਉਣਾ (āuṇā)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 23

to eat — and the letter next door that stopped being a**consonant and became a tone ਖਾਣਾ (khāṇā)**

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 7, p. 23

to go — and the one sound law that turns Sanskrit words into**Punjabi ones ਜਾਣਾ (jāṇā)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 23

to help — literally “to do help,” and the help half is Arabic मदद**ਕਰਨਾ (madad karnā)**

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 41

to know — one letter away from “to go,” and the same word as**English know ਜਾਣਨਾ (jāṇṇā)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 23

to live, to stay ਰਹਿਣਾ

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 15

to read — and in the language it came from, reading meant**saying it out loud ਪੜ੍ਹਨਾ (paṛhṇā)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 33

to see — built on the old word for the eye itself, the root behind**eye, optic, and window ਵੇਖਣਾ (vekhṇā)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 23

to speak ਬੋਲਣਾ

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 15

to take — a verb that lost a whole consonant on the way**here ਲੈਣਾ (laiṇā)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 41

to think — a verb that started out meaning to burn, and then to**grieve ਸੋਚਣਾ (sochṇā)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 33

to understand — from a root meaning “to wake up,” and the word carries a tone ਸਮਝਣਾ (samajhṇā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 33

to work (lit. “work-do”) ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 15

to write — from a root meaning to scratch, which is how three unrelated languages named it ਲਿਖਣਾ (likhṇā)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 33

W

water — Punjabi’s first noun for something you would actually ask for, and the phrase that asks for it politely ਪਾਣੀ (pāṇī)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 49

Water, Tea, Milk, and Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 49

we’ll meet again (goodbye) ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 13

(we) will meet ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 13

what ਕੀ

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

what’s your name? ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ?

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 5

Why two branches both arrived at *panj*

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 19

Y

yes / no (hāṇ / nahīṇ) ਹਾਂ / ਨਹੀਂ

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

you (familiar / respectful) ਤੂੰ / ਤੁਸੀਂ

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

Other

ਤ — the consonant ta

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

ਨ — the consonant na

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

ਨਮਸਤੇ — **five pieces, all of them already yours**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

ਮ — **the consonant ma**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

ਸ — **the consonant sa**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71

ਹ — **the consonant ha**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 14, p. 71